

PFL-AI Body of Knowledge

The reference for the PCI AI Project Finance Leader
Project economics · structuring · financial mathematics · the
governed use of AI

FIRST EDITION — PHASE 1 PROTOTYPE (NOT FOR RELEASE)

PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL

Finance intelligently. Control predictively. Deliver successfully.

AI proposes; the professional verifies, decides and remains accountable.

— Prototype notice

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01

PART ONE

Foundations

Domains 1–4 — the profession, accounting foundations, financial mathematics and investment appraisal: the financial grammar of project finance leadership.



01

DOMAIN 1

Foundations of Project Finance Leadership

Group: Foundations (Domain 1 of 4 in Part One). **Target:** ~66 pages. **Binds to:** the PCI Book Pattern Specification and the shared registries ([docs/books/registries/](#)). This domain fixes the book's core vocabulary — recourse, SPV, sponsor, bankability, CFADS (introduced by name, built fully in Domain 10) — and the stakeholder map every later domain assumes. British English; USD (+SAR where useful, indicative USD 1 ≈ SAR 3.75).

— Why this domain exists

Project finance is a distinctive answer to a distinctive problem: how to fund a large, long-lived, single-purpose asset whose only security is itself — its contracts and the cash they will produce. This domain establishes what makes that answer work, and what the leader at the centre of it actually does. It maps the role across the project lifecycle (KA 1.1), builds the discipline's three-cornered logic — value, cash and risk (KA 1.2) — and grounds the profession's obligations: fiduciary awareness, independence, and the governed use of AI (KA 1.3). Everything later in the book is a specialisation of this domain: the mathematics (Domains 3-4), the structures (Domains 5, 9, 12), the lender's machinery (Domains 10, 13-15) and the AI curriculum (Domain 16) all stand on the concepts fixed here. A reader who finishes only this domain should already reason like the profession: follow the cash, price the risk, know who bears it, and stay accountable.

Learning objectives. After this domain a candidate can: describe the project finance leader's role at each lifecycle stage; place a financing on the recourse spectrum and explain what limited recourse buys and costs; explain the SPV's purpose and the interests of each party around it; describe the infrastructure-finance market's asset classes and investors; explain why cash, not profit, is the binding constraint and demonstrate the difference; explain leverage's amplification of equity returns and of risk with a computed example; state the risk-return-bankability logic; and apply the profession's ethical and responsible-AI obligations to realistic situations.

The master thread. Kestrel Water SPC — whose loan, availability stream and investment case Domains 3 and 4 priced — began here: a sponsor group weighing how to finance a desalination plant at all. This domain tells that part of the story; Domain 5 takes the project through development to bankability.

KNOWLEDGE AREA 1.1

The project finance leader and the financing landscape

Topics: 1.1.1 the role across the lifecycle · 1.1.2 corporate versus project finance — the recourse spectrum · 1.1.3 the SPV and its stakeholders · 1.1.4 the infrastructure-finance market.

1.1.1 The role across the lifecycle

The project finance leader is the person accountable for a project's **financial integrity end to end** — not the deal-closer alone, and not the accountant alone. The role changes costume by stage while keeping one spine:

Stage	What the finance leader owns
Development	Screening economics (Domain 4); funding development spend at risk; shaping a financeable concept (Domain 5)
Structuring	Capital structure and funding sources (Domain 9); risk allocation into contracts (Domains 11–12)
Execution (financial close)	Due diligence, model audit, documentation, conditions precedent (Domain 13)
Construction	Drawdowns, cost-to-complete, lender reporting (Domain 14)
Operations	Covenant compliance, waterfall management, distributions, refinancing (Domain 15)
Maturity/exit	Handback, sale, restructuring where needed (Domain 15)

The spine is a single question asked at every stage: **will the cash arrive, and who is exposed if it does not?** The leader's authority rests on being the person in the room who can answer it with evidence.

1.1.2 Corporate versus project finance — the recourse spectrum

Definitions. In **corporate (balance-sheet) finance**, lenders lend to a company and are repaid from its whole cash flow; every asset stands behind every debt. In **project finance**, lenders lend to a ring-fenced project and are repaid **only from that project's cash flows**, with security over its assets and contracts — **non-recourse** to the sponsors, or **limited recourse** where sponsors give bounded support (a completion guarantee, a cost-overflow facility). Real deals sit on a spectrum between the poles.

What limited recourse buys sponsors: risk containment (a failed project cannot sink the parent), balance-sheet capacity, the ability to share a mega-project among partners, and discipline — lenders' due diligence becomes a second pair of eyes on every assumption. What it costs: higher margins and fees (lenders carry risk they cannot chase a parent for), heavy transaction and diligence costs, long documentation timelines, and covenant control over the project's cash (Domain 10). The break-even is scale and risk-shape: single-asset, contract-backed, capital-intensive projects with long lives are where the machinery pays.

Fig 1.1.1 — The recourse spectrum

1.1.3 The SPV and its stakeholders

Definition. The **special-purpose vehicle (SPV)** is a company created to do exactly one thing — own, build, finance and operate the project — and legally incapable of doing anything else. Ring-fencing is what makes non-recourse lending possible: the SPV's contracts are its assets, and every major relationship is written down (Domain 12 builds the contract matrix in full).

The parties and what each optimises:

Party	Wants	Watches
Sponsors (equity)	Return on equity; contained risk; distributions	Equity IRR, distribution tests
Lenders	Repayment with margin; downside protection	DSCR/LLCR, covenants, security (Domain 10)
Offtaker / grantor	Reliable service at agreed price	Availability, tariffs, handback condition
EPC contractor	Construction margin	Variations, delay LDs (Domain 12)
Operator (O&M)	Fee; performance regime it can meet	Availability/output guarantees
Government / regulator	Delivery of policy outcomes; compliance	Permits, obligations, public interest
Community & environment	Benefit without harm	E&S performance (Domain 11)

The finance leader's daily craft is reconciling these optimisations inside one cash flow — which is why the cash waterfall (Domain 15) reads like a peace treaty.

Fig 1.1.2 — The SPV at the centre of its contracts

1.1.4 The infrastructure-finance market

The asset classes and their financing habits, in one professional sweep: **transport** (toll roads, rail, airports — patronage or availability models); **power and renewables** (PPAs, capacity markets; the energy transition's build-out is the market's largest engine); **water** (desalination and treatment concessions — Kestrel's world); **digital infrastructure** (data centres, towers, fibre — shorter refresh cycles, credit-tenant leases); **social infrastructure** (hospitals, schools, housing under availability PPPs); and **natural resources** (commodity-linked, price-hedged). The capital comes from commercial banks (construction-phase specialists), institutional investors and infrastructure funds (long-dated operations-phase capital), export credit agencies and development banks (Domain 9), and bond markets (refinancing bankable operating assets). The leader's market literacy is matching **asset shape to capital shape**: construction risk to banks and ECAs, stabilised cash flows to institutions — mismatches are expensive at best and fatal at close.

AI in this KA

Market screening and precedent research are natural AI accelerants — summarising comparable transactions, extracting terms from public disclosures, drafting stakeholder maps. The governed habits start in Domain 1 because the failure modes do: a fluent but invented "precedent transaction" is this profession's textbook hallucination case. Sources are verified against the registry discipline (every claimed deal traced to a public record), and the stakeholder analysis an AI drafts is walked, party by party, by someone who has sat across from those parties. **AI proposes; the professional verifies, decides and remains accountable.**

■ KEY TERMS — KA 1.1

Term	Meaning
Recourse / non-recourse / limited recourse	Whom the lender can pursue: the sponsor's balance sheet; the project only; the project plus bounded sponsor support.
SPV	Ring-fenced single-purpose project company; the borrower and contract hub.
Sponsor	Equity investor promoting the project (this book's project-finance sense).
Offtaker	The buyer of the project's output or service under contract.
Ring-fencing	Legal isolation of the project's assets, contracts and cash.
Asset-capital matching	Pairing project risk phases with the capital suited to hold them.

■ SAMPLE MCQS — KA 1.1

MCQ 1.1-A [1.1.2 · Application] A sponsor gives lenders a guarantee that covers cost overruns until the plant passes its completion test, after which lenders may look only to project cash flows. This financing is best described as: - A. full recourse - B. non-recourse - C. limited recourse - D. unsecured corporate lending

Rationale: Bounded sponsor support (here, to completion) between the poles is the defining shape of limited recourse. A would expose the sponsor for the loan's life; B would mean no sponsor support at all; D abandons both the security package and the ring-fence.

MCQ 1.1-B [1.1.3 · Analysis] Which single feature of the SPV makes non-recourse lending possible? - A. its tax registration - B. legal ring-fencing: the SPV can conduct only the project, so its contracts and cash are isolated and chargeable - C. its sponsors' credit ratings - D. the size of its share capital

Rationale: Lenders can accept project-only recourse because the ring-fence guarantees no other business can dilute, encumber or divert the cash they are lending against. C reverses the concept (sponsor credit is what non-recourse lending does without); A and D are administrative facts, not the mechanism.

MCQ 1.1-C [1.1.4 · Application] A fund holding long-dated pension liabilities wants infrastructure exposure. The asset-capital matching principle points it toward: - A. construction-phase risk in a greenfield project - B. stabilised operating assets with contracted cash flows - C. development-stage equity at risk - D. short-term bridge lending

Rationale: Long-dated stable liabilities match long-dated stable cash flows. A and C sit where construction and development specialists (banks, ECAs, developers) hold the risk; D matches a treasury desk, not a pension profile.

■ SELF-CHECK — KA 1.1

1. State the finance leader's one recurring question. — Will the cash arrive, and who is exposed if it does not?
2. Name two things limited recourse buys a sponsor and two things it costs. — Buys: risk containment, balance-sheet capacity (also partnering, lender discipline). Costs: pricing and fees, transaction complexity (also covenant control, time).
3. Why does every party around the SPV get a contract? — Non-recourse credit is built from contracts: each relationship must be enforceable because the cash flow is the only security.

KNOWLEDGE AREA 1.2

Value, cash and risk: the discipline's logic

Topics: 1.2.1 value creation in projects · 1.2.2 cash as the binding constraint · 1.2.3 leverage, risk and the bankability triangle.

1.2.1 Value creation in projects

A project creates value when the present value of what it will produce exceeds what it costs to build and run — Domain 4's NPV, stated in words. The foundation point is where value can be created or destroyed by financing: structure does not conjure value from a bad project, but it can (1) allocate each risk to the party who bears it cheapest — lowering the priced-in premiums; (2) match capital to risk phase — lowering the blended cost of funds; and (3) impose diligence and covenant discipline that keeps forecast value from leaking in execution. The corollary the profession lives by: **financing engineering amplifies project quality; it never substitutes for it.**

1.2.2 Cash, not profit, is the binding constraint

The principle. Profit is an opinion about periods (Domain 2's accrual model); **cash pays debt service.** Projects die of cash exhaustion, usually while reporting profits.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Worked example 1.2.2 — profitable and out of cash.

1. **Setup.** In its first operating quarter a project company recognises revenue of USD 10,000,000 against costs of USD 8,000,000. But customers have paid only 7,000,000 of the revenue (receivables +3,000,000); spare-parts inventory was built up by 1,000,000; and suppliers extended 500,000 of additional credit (payables +500,000).
2. **Formula.** Operating cash flow = profit – Δ receivables – Δ inventory + Δ payables.
3. **Substitution.** 2,000,000 – 3,000,000 – 1,000,000 + 500,000.
4. **Result.** Profit +USD 2,000,000; operating cash flow –USD 1,500,000.
5. **Interpretation.** The same quarter is a success in the income statement and a crisis in the bank account: a 2.0m "profitable" company is 1.5m short of the cash its debt service assumed. This is why lenders size and test debt against **CFADS** — cash flow available for debt service (defined fully in Domain 10) — and why every model in Domain 6 is a cash model first. Domain 2 builds the full accrual-to-cash bridge.

1.2.3 Leverage, risk and the bankability triangle

Leverage amplifies. Debt is cheaper than equity, and fixed: whatever the project earns, debt service is owed. That fixity cuts both ways.

WORKED EXAMPLE**Worked example 1.2.3 — the two faces of leverage.**

1. **Setup.** A project costs USD 100,000,000 and produces steady operating cash of USD 12,000,000 per year. Compare an all-equity structure with 70 % debt (USD 70,000,000, interest-only at 6.0 % = 4,200,000 per year), in the base case and with cash down 25 % and 50 %.
2. **Formula.** Unlevered return = cash / 100,000,000. Equity cash = cash – 4,200,000; levered return = equity cash / 30,000,000.
3. **Substitution.** Base: $12.0 - 4.2 = 7.8$ on 30. Down 25 %: $9.0 - 4.2 = 4.8$. Down 50 %: $6.0 - 4.2 = 1.8$.
4. **Result.**

Scenario	Project cash	Unlevered return	Equity cash	Levered return
Base	12,000,000	12.0 %	7,800,000	26.0 %
–25 %	9,000,000	9.0 %	4,800,000	16.0 %
–50 %	6,000,000	6.0 %	1,800,000	6.0 %
–65 %	4,200,000	4.2 %	0	0.0 %

1. **Interpretation.** Leverage more than doubles the base-case equity return (26 % vs 12 %) — and makes the downside three times steeper (26 → 6 % as cash halves, versus 12 → 6 % unlevered). At a 65 % cash decline the equity earns nothing and the lender is next in line. Gearing is chosen, not maximised: Domain 9 structures it, Domain 10 shows how lenders cap it with coverage ratios sized precisely against scenarios like this table.

The bankability triangle. Three tests every financing must pass simultaneously: **value** (the project is worth doing — Domain 4), **cash** (the flows arrive in the periods that need them — Domains 6–8), and **risk allocation** (each hazard sits with a party able and bound to bear it — Domains 11–12). A project strong on two corners and weak on one is not two-thirds bankable; it is unbankable until the corner is fixed. **Bankability** (built fully in Domain 5) is precisely the state of passing all three tests in the eyes of the capital being asked to commit.

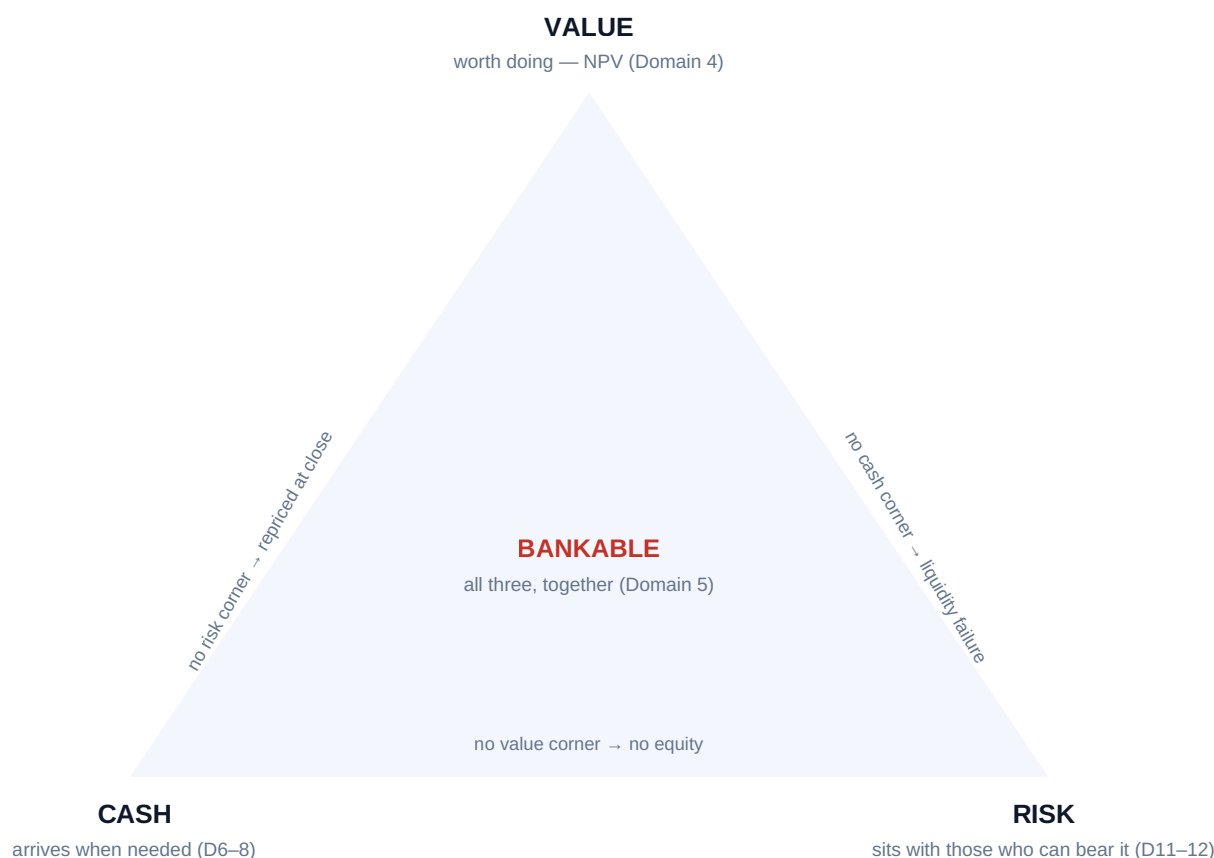


Fig 1.2.1 — The bankability triangle

AI in this KA

Scenario tables like 1.2.3's are ideal machine work — and the place where a subtly wrong fixed-charge assumption (interest-only vs amortising; Domain 3's shapes) silently reshapes every row. The governed pattern: the machine drafts the grid; the analyst re-derives one row by hand and checks the boundary case (where equity cash crosses zero) analytically; the leader reads the downside rows first, because that is what the structure is actually being designed against.

■ KEY TERMS — KA 1.2

Term	Meaning
CFADS	Cash flow available for debt service (name fixed here; machinery in Domain 10).
Working capital drag	Cash absorbed by receivables and inventory ahead of profit.
Leverage / gearing	Debt's share of funding; amplifier of equity return and risk.
Fixed charge	Debt service owed regardless of performance.
Bankability triangle	Value + cash + risk allocation, passed together.

■ SAMPLE MCQS — KA 1.2

MCQ 1.2-A [1.2.2 · Application] A company reports quarterly profit of 2,000,000 while receivables rose 3,000,000, inventory rose 1,000,000 and payables rose 500,000. Its operating cash flow is: - A. +2,000,000 - B. -1,500,000 - C. +500,000 - D. -2,500,000

Rationale: $2.0 - 3.0 - 1.0 + 0.5 = -1.5m$. A stops at profit; C nets only the payables against profit and forgets the asset build; D subtracts the payables increase instead of adding it — supplier credit is a cash source.

MCQ 1.2-B [1.2.3 · Application] In the leverage example (70m debt, interest-only 6 %; equity 30m), project cash of 9,000,000 produces a levered equity return of: - A. 9.0 % - B. 16.0 % - C. 26.0 % - D. 30.0 %

Rationale: $(9.0 - 4.2)/30 = 16.0\%$. A is the unlevered return; C is the base-case levered return; D divides project cash by equity without paying the lender first.

MCQ 1.2-C [1.2.3 · Analysis] A project shows strong NPV and well-allocated risks, but its revenue arrives seasonally while debt service is quarterly and level. The bankability verdict is: - A. bankable — two of three corners suffice - B. unbankable as structured: the cash corner fails; reshape the debt profile or add liquidity support - C. unbankable permanently — reject the project - D. bankable if the sponsors accept a higher equity IRR

Rationale: The triangle is conjunctive: mistimed cash defeats value and allocation. The cure is structural (sculpted or seasonal debt service, reserve accounts — Domains 9–10), not rejection (C) and not a return adjustment that changes nothing about timing (D).

■ SELF-CHECK — KA 1.2

1. Why do lenders test CFADS rather than profit? — Debt service is paid in cash; accrual profit can coexist with cash exhaustion (WE 1.2.2).
2. State leverage's two faces in one sentence each. — It multiplies the equity return on the same project cash; it makes every downside steeper because debt service is fixed.
3. Why is the triangle conjunctive? — Each corner defeats the financing alone: no value → no equity; no cash timing → default risk regardless of value; no allocation → risk premia or collapse at close.

KNOWLEDGE AREA 1.3

Ethics, fiduciary awareness and responsible AI

Topics: 1.3.1 obligations and duties · 1.3.2 conflicts and independence · 1.3.3 the responsible-AI principle in finance.

1.3.1 Obligations and duties

The project finance leader acts inside a lattice of duties: **fiduciary-type duties** to the employer or client (loyalty, care, confidentiality); **contractual duties** under mandates and finance documents; **statutory duties** (companies law, anti-bribery and corruption, sanctions, market conduct); and **professional duties** — competence, candour, and records that let others check the work. Two standing disciplines follow. Candour about numbers: forecasts are presented with their assumptions and sensitivities, never as certainties (Domain 4, KA 4.3.3); an optimistic case knowingly presented as a base case is a misrepresentation, whatever the spreadsheet says. Candour about limits: this

book's own rule — educational reference, not individualized advice; jurisdiction-specific matters go to qualified counsel and advisers — is the same professional humility applied to oneself.

1.3.2 Conflicts and independence

Project finance concentrates conflicts because the same institutions recur in many roles: the adviser who would earn a success fee on close; the sponsor-affiliated contractor pricing the EPC; the bank advising the government while lending to bidders. The professional machinery is disclosure and separation: conflicts are declared before engagement, managed with information barriers or declined; advice and self-interest are never silently blended. The leader's test for any arrangement is the daylight test — would every party, seeing the full fee and relationship map, still regard the advice as independent? Where the answer wavers, independence has already failed. (Case study B applies this to a live tender; Domain 13's diligence streams exist partly to give lenders advice that passes the test.)

1.3.3 The responsible-AI principle in finance

The suite principle — **AI proposes; the professional verifies, decides and remains accountable** — lands hardest in finance, where machine output looks like the work product itself (a model, a memo, a covenant summary). Domain 16 builds the full governance architecture; the foundations fixed here:

- **Verification is not optional and not delegable to the tool.** Golden-answer checks for calculations (the discipline this book applies to itself); source-tracing for claims; document-against-summary checks for AI-read contracts.
- **Accountability cannot be transferred.** "The model said so" is never a defence — the signing professional owns the output as if hand-made.
- **Confidentiality travels with the data.** Deal information entering an AI tool is a disclosure; it happens only within approved, contracted environments.
- **Material AI use is disclosed** within the team and, where it touches deliverables, to the client — the daylight test again, applied to method.

■ KEY TERMS — KA 1.3

Term	Meaning
Fiduciary awareness	Acting in the principal's interest with loyalty, care and confidentiality.
Conflict of interest	An interest that could bias judgment; declared, managed or declined.
Daylight test	Would full disclosure of interests leave the advice trusted?
Responsible-AI principle	AI proposes; the professional verifies, decides, remains accountable.
Verification duty	The named human's obligation to check machine output before reliance.

■ SAMPLE MCQS — KA 1.3

MCQ 1.3-A [1.3.1 · Analysis] An analyst is asked to present the upside case as the base case "because the committee needs confidence". The professional response is: - A. comply — labels are a presentation choice - B. decline: presenting a knowingly optimistic case as the base misrepresents the forecast; offer the honest base with sensitivities instead - C. comply, but keep a private note of the true base - D. resign immediately without discussion

Rationale: Candour about numbers is a duty, not a style (A); a private note documents the misrepresentation without preventing it (C); B both refuses the breach and offers the legitimate route to confidence — evidence. D skips the professional obligation to fix the problem before escalating personal exits.

MCQ 1.3-B [1.3.2 · Application] A bank advising a grantor on a tender also wishes to lend to one of the bidders. The minimum acceptable handling is: - A. proceed — different departments are involved - B. disclose the dual role to the grantor, and either obtain informed consent with effective information barriers or decline one role - C. keep the lending discussion confidential until after award - D. advise the grantor to select that bidder

Rationale: Disclosure plus genuine separation (or declination) is the standing machinery; department labels alone are not barriers (A); concealment converts a conflict into misconduct (C); D is the conflict operating in the open.

MCQ 1.3-C [1.3.3 · Recall] Under the PCI responsible-AI principle, responsibility for an AI-drafted covenant summary used in a credit paper rests with: - A. the AI vendor - B. the model itself - C. the professional who verified, signed and used it - D. nobody, if the tool was approved

Rationale: Accountability cannot be delegated to software or its supplier; tool approval governs which tools may be used, never who answers for the output.

■ SELF-CHECK — KA 1.3

1. State the daylight test. — Would every party, seeing the full relationship and fee map, still trust the advice as independent?
2. What three checks make AI-assisted work professionally usable? — Recomputed numbers (golden checks), traced sources, document-against-summary verification — by a named human.
3. Why does confidentiality bind AI use? — Data entering a tool is a disclosure; it must stay within approved, contracted environments.

— Industry variations — Domain 1

The foundations flex by sector mainly in who the counterparties are: in **power and water**, the offtaker is often a state utility — sovereign credit and political risk enter the stakeholder map (Domain 11); in **transport**, the "offtaker" may be the travelling public — demand risk reshapes the whole triangle; in **social PPPs**, the grantor's availability payment makes government the cash engine and handback condition a first-order obligation; in **digital infrastructure**, corporate credit-tenants replace state offtakers and refresh cycles shorten every horizon; in **natural resources**, the market itself is the offtaker and hedging policy joins the foundations. The leader's first map in any new sector: who pays, under what compulsion, and what can stop them.

— Case study — Domain 1: how Kestrel chose project finance (water)

Situation. Kestrel's two sponsors — an international water operator and a regional infrastructure fund — faced a USD 100,000,000 plant with a 25-year availability offtake. Corporate borrowing was available to the operator at attractive rates; the fund could not guarantee anything beyond its equity.

Analysis. Corporate route: cheapest debt, fastest close — but the operator alone carries 100 % of construction and performance risk on its balance sheet, the fund cannot participate on equal terms, and a project failure would impair the operator's whole credit. Project route: an SPV with limited-recourse debt (completion support only), 70/30 gearing — pricier debt and eighteen months of structuring, but risk contained at the ring-fence, the partners aligned through one shareholders' agreement, and lender diligence pressure-testing every assumption (the discipline dividend of 1.2.1). The leverage table of WE 1.2.3 gave the equity story; the triangle gave the test — value (Domain 4's +16.18m NPV), cash (the availability stream priced in Domain 3), risk (allocated through the contract matrix built later in Domain 12).

The decision. Project finance — not because it was cheaper (it was not), but because it made the partnership possible, contained the downside, and converted lender scrutiny into project quality. The minute records the recourse position, the support obligations and their sunset at completion — the exact vocabulary of KA 1.1.2.

What the domain teaches here. The financing route is a risk and partnership decision before it is a cost decision; the cheapest debt attached to the wrong recourse shape is the expensive option.

— Case study B — Domain 1: the adviser with two hats (transport tender)

Situation. A grantor's financial adviser on a toll-road tender was discovered — after preferred-bidder selection — to hold an advisory mandate for the winning consortium's lead sponsor on an unrelated deal, undisclosed. The losing bidders challenged; the award was suspended pending review.

What happened. The review found no evidence the evaluation was slanted — and it did not matter. The undisclosed relationship alone failed the daylight test: the tender was re-run with a new adviser at a cost of fourteen months and the grantor's credibility, and the adviser's firm lost its public-sector practice in the jurisdiction. A one-line disclosure at engagement, with barriers or a declined mandate, would have cost nothing.

What the domain teaches here. Conflicts are priced at discovery, not at occurrence — and the price is paid in time, trust and franchise, not fees. Independence is an asset that only disclosure can insure.

— Executive perspective — Domain 1

What a project finance director cannot delegate in this domain:

- **The recourse position.** Exactly what the sponsor stands behind, until when, capped at what — the director signs this sentence personally and re-reads it before every support call.
- **The stakeholder map's honesty.** Every party's real incentive, including the uncomfortable ones, on one page the board has seen.
- **The cash question.** Asked in every meeting until it embarrasses no one: will the cash arrive, and who is exposed if it does not?
- **The conflicts register.** Kept current, disclosed early, tested against daylight — because the director's own relationships are usually the largest entries.
- **The AI accountability line.** Named humans own machine output; the director owns the culture that makes that real (Domain 16 gives the machinery; Domain 1 gives the law).

— Calculation exercises — Domain 1

Exercise 1.1 Profit 3,500,000; receivables +2,200,000; inventory +900,000; payables +600,000. Operating cash flow? Solution. $3.5 - 2.2 - 0.9 + 0.6 = \text{+USD } 1,000,000$. Common error: sign on payables (supplier credit is a source: +0.6, not -0.6; the wrong sign gives -0.2m and a false alarm).

Exercise 1.2 The WE 1.2.3 project refinances to 80 % debt (80,000,000 interest-only at 6.5 %). Rebuild the base-case levered return and the cash decline at which equity income reaches zero. Solution. Debt service $80 \times 0.065 = 5,200,000$; equity 20,000,000; base equity cash $12.0 - 5.2 = 6.8 \rightarrow 34.0\%$. Zero at project cash = 5,200,000 — a **56.7 % decline** (from 12.0). Versus the 70/30 case: two points more base return (34 vs 26 %... on a third less equity) bought a materially nearer cliff (-56.7 % vs -65 %). Common error: comparing levered percentages without comparing the cliffs.

Exercise 1.3 Classify: (a) parent guarantees debt until completion test, then released; (b) parent comfort letter, non-binding; (c) no support, reserves funded from cash flow. Solution. (a) limited recourse; (b) effectively non-recourse in law — comfort letters are generally not enforceable guarantees (jurisdiction-specific; counsel confirms); (c) non-recourse with structural mitigation. Common error: treating a comfort letter as recourse — lenders price it as goodwill, not security.

— Practitioner's toolkit — Domain 1

Adoption-ready artefacts; adapt headings to your organisation, then keep them stable.

Toolkit 1.T.1 — Stakeholder map (one page per project)

Per party: name and role · what they optimise · contract binding them (Domain 12 reference) · cash flows to/from the SPV · veto points and consents · relationship owner. Rule: the map is board-visible and includes the uncomfortable incentives.

Toolkit 1.T.2 — Financing-route decision record

Options considered (corporate / limited recourse / non-recourse / hybrid) · recourse sentence per option (who stands behind what, until when, capped at what) · pricing and cost deltas · partnership and balance-sheet effects · risk containment analysis (triangle test per option) · decision, rationale, decision-maker, date.

Toolkit 1.T.3 — Conflicts and AI-use register

Conflicts: relationship · parties affected · disclosure date · handling (barriers/consent/ declined) · review date. AI use: tool and environment · data classification cleared · verification steps and named verifier · disclosure status. One register, one owner, standing agenda item.

— Exam preparation — Domain 1

The traps. Recourse classifications (comfort letter $\neq$ guarantee — Exercise 1.3) · payables sign in the cash bridge (Exercise 1.1) · levered-return arithmetic that skips debt service (MCQ 1.2-B

distractor D) · reading the triangle as two-out-of-three · "sponsor" meaning equity investor in this book's project-finance chapters (terminology registry) · assigning AI accountability anywhere but the signing professional.

Reflection questions. 1. Take a project you know: write its recourse sentence in under 25 words. Who stands behind what, until when, capped at what? 2. Which corner of the bankability triangle does your current project stress most — and what structural (not cosmetic) fix would close it? 3. What in your team's current AI usage would fail the daylight test if disclosed in full — and what changes tomorrow because you asked?

— Domain 1 summary

Project finance funds single-purpose assets against their own cash, made possible by the ring-fenced SPV and priced along the recourse spectrum; the leader's role is the financial integrity of that machine across the whole lifecycle, under one recurring question — will the cash arrive, and who is exposed if it does not? The discipline's logic triangulates value, cash and risk: financing amplifies project quality but never substitutes for it; cash, not profit, binds (a profitable quarter can be a cash crisis); leverage multiplies returns and steepens every downside, which is why lenders will later cap it with coverage machinery. Around the technique stands the profession: fiduciary-grade candour about numbers and limits, conflicts managed in daylight, and machine assistance governed by the suite principle — AI proposes; the professional verifies, decides and remains accountable. Domain 2 builds the accounting the cash bridge assumed; Domain 5 takes Kestrel from concept to bankability.

02

DOMAIN 2

Accounting and Financial-Statement Foundations

Group: Foundations (Domain 2 of 4 in Part One). **Target:** ~70 pages. **Binds to:** the PCI Book Pattern Specification and the shared registries ([docs/books/registries/](#)). This domain builds the accrual-to-cash bridge Domain 1 promised and supplies the statement vocabulary every later domain assumes — including the **CFADS** that Domain 10 turns into coverage ratios. Standards are named and described in this book's own words; no standard's text is reproduced, and nothing here is accounting advice for a specific entity or jurisdiction. British English; USD (+SAR where useful, indicative **USD 1 ≈ SAR 3.75**).

— Why this domain exists

Domain 1 established that **cash, not profit, is the binding constraint** — and then left an obligation outstanding: if profit is not the thing that pays debt service, why does anyone compute it, and how do you get from one to the other? This domain discharges that obligation. It builds the accrual model and what recognition actually means (KA 2.1); assembles the three statements and the articulation that binds them into one system (KA 2.2); works the treatments that decide a project's reported numbers — working capital, revenue and cost recognition, capital versus operating expenditure, provisions (KA 2.3); and closes with ratio interpretation and the interfaces between project reporting and corporate accounts (KA 2.4). A project finance leader is not an accountant, and this domain does not try to make one. It makes something more specific: a leader who can read a set of statements, find the cash inside them, and tell when an accounting choice has changed the picture without changing the economics.

Learning objectives. After this domain a candidate can: explain accrual accounting and the recognition tests that drive it; describe each of the three statements and what question it answers; **articulate** a statement set — derive the cash-flow statement from profit and the balance-sheet movements, and prove it reconciles; explain how working capital consumes cash and compute its effect on **CFADS** and therefore on a coverage ratio; distinguish capital from operating expenditure and quantify the profit effect of the choice while showing cash is unaffected; explain provisions and contingent liabilities in principle; interpret the core ratios including interest cover; describe the interfaces between project cost systems and corporate reporting; and govern AI-assisted analysis of financial statements.

The master statements. Kestrel Water SPC — whose loan, appraisal and financing decision Domains 1, 3 and 4 built — now reports its **first full operating year**. The plant cost **USD 60,000,000** (Domain 4's **I₆**), depreciated straight-line over **25 years**. The senior loan is Domain 3's **USD 42,000,000 at 6.0 % over 12 years**, so year-one interest is **USD 2,520,000** and the annual instalment is **USD 5,009,635**. Revenue is **USD 12,000,000**, cash operating costs **USD 4,500,000**, and tax is charged at **20 %**. Every figure in KA 2.2–2.4 derives from these.

KNOWLEDGE AREA 2.1

The accrual model

Topics: 2.1.1 accrual versus cash accounting · 2.1.2 recognition · 2.1.3 the statements as one system.

2.1.1 Accrual versus cash accounting

Definitions. **Cash accounting** records a transaction when money moves. **Accrual accounting** records the effects of transactions when they occur, regardless of when money moves — revenue when it is earned, expenses when they are incurred. Accrual is the basis of general-purpose financial reporting because cash timing is a poor guide to performance: a project that invoices in December and collects in February did the work in December, and a cash-basis account would report a loss followed by a windfall.

The two bases answer different questions, and a finance leader needs both:

Basis	Answers	Where it governs
Accrual	Did we perform profitably in this period?	Statutory accounts, covenants defined on profit, tax
Cash	Can we pay what falls due?	Debt service, drawdowns, liquidity, CFADS (Domain 10)

The professional consequence. Accrual and cash diverge, and the divergence is information, not noise. A project reporting healthy profit while operating cash falls is telling you something precise — usually that working capital is absorbing the difference (KA 2.3.1). Domain 1's worked example was exactly this case; this domain now shows the machinery that produces it.

2.1.2 Recognition

Definition. **Recognition** is recording an item in the statements as an asset, liability, income or expense. It is governed by tests, not by preference, and the tests are the substance of what accounting standards do. Described in principle (IFRS is the framework referenced throughout this book by name):

- An **asset** is a present economic resource controlled by the entity as a result of past events — recognised when it exists and can be measured reliably. Control, not legal title, is the operative idea.
- A **liability** is a present obligation to transfer an economic resource as a result of past events. A future intention is not a liability, however certain it feels.
- **Income and expenses** are recognised as the underlying changes in assets and liabilities occur, which is why revenue recognition follows performance (KA 2.3.2) rather than invoicing.

Measurement then asks at what amount — historical cost, amortised cost, fair value — and the choice materially changes reported figures without changing any cash flow. That sentence is the whole reason a finance leader reads statements sceptically: **recognition and measurement policies are part of the answer, so they must be part of the question.**

2.1.3 The statements as one system

The three primary statements are not three reports; they are three views of one set of facts, locked together by identities:

Assets = Liabilities + Equity (the balance sheet identity)
 Closing equity = Opening equity + Profit – Distributions (+ capital contributed)
 Closing cash = Opening cash + Operating + Investing + Financing cash flows

Because they share one underlying record, a change in one propagates to all three — the property called **articulation**, demonstrated arithmetically in KA 2.2.4. Articulation is the reader's single most powerful tool: a statement set that does not articulate contains an error or an omission, and finding where it fails localises the problem immediately.

AI in this KA

Statement analysis is a genuine AI strength — extracting line items, restating across periods, flagging unusual movements — and it has a specific, dangerous blind spot: a model reads the numbers fluently and the policies not at all. Two projects with identical economics and different capitalisation or revenue-recognition policies produce different statements, and an assistant comparing them will report a difference in performance that does not exist. The governed habit: ask what policy produced each figure before comparing any two entities or periods, and verify extracted line items against the source statement. **AI proposes; the professional verifies, decides and remains accountable.**

■ KEY TERMS — KA 2.1

Term	Meaning
Accrual basis	Recognising the effects of transactions when they occur, not when cash moves.
Recognition	Recording an item in the statements, subject to definition and measurement tests.
Measurement	The amount at which a recognised item is carried (cost, amortised cost, fair value).
Articulation	The locking of the three statements to one underlying record via identities.
Accounting policy	The permitted choice that shapes reported figures without changing cash.

■ SAMPLE MCQS — KA 2.1

MCQ 2.1-A [2.1.1 · Analysis] A project reports rising profit and falling operating cash flow over three quarters, with no change in accounting policy. The most likely explanation is: - A. the profit figures must be erroneous - B. working capital is absorbing cash — receivables and/or inventory are growing faster than payables - C. depreciation has increased - D. the two measures are unrelated, so no explanation is needed

Rationale: Accrual profit and operating cash diverge principally through working-capital movements (KA 2.3.1). C would raise operating cash relative to profit (a non-cash charge added back), and D denies the articulation the statements are built on.

MCQ 2.1-B [2.1.2 · Application] A sponsor board has firmly resolved to fund a plant upgrade next year. At this year end this is: - A. a liability, because the decision is certain - B. not a liability — there is no present obligation from a past event; an intention is not an obligation - C. a provision, because the amount is estimable - D. a contingent asset

Rationale: Liability recognition requires a present obligation arising from a past event (2.1.2). Certainty of intent is irrelevant; a provision (C) still requires an obligation to exist, and D inverts the direction entirely.

MCQ 2.1-C [2.1.3 · Recall] A statement set where the cash-flow statement's closing cash does not equal the balance sheet's cash indicates: - A. a normal difference in presentation - B. an error or omission — the statements articulate to one record, so they must reconcile - C. the use of accrual rather than cash accounting - D. a foreign-currency effect that requires no action

Rationale: Articulation is an identity (2.1.3). FX and presentation differences are disclosed and reconciled, not left unbalanced — an unreconciled set is a defect, and locating the break is the reader's fastest diagnostic.

■ SELF-CHECK — KA 2.1

1. Which basis governs debt service, and which governs covenants defined on profit? — Cash for debt service; accrual for profit-defined covenants. A leader needs both.
2. Why is an intention never a liability? — Recognition requires a present obligation arising from a past event.
3. What does a failure to articulate tell you? — That there is an error or omission, and where the break occurs localises it.

KNOWLEDGE AREA 2.2

The three statements and their articulation

Topics: 2.2.1 the income statement · 2.2.2 the balance sheet · 2.2.3 the cash-flow statement · 2.2.4 articulation demonstrated.

2.2.1 The income statement

What it answers: did the entity perform profitably in the period? Its project-finance-relevant structure runs down from revenue through the layers a lender reads:

WORKED EXAMPLE

Worked example 2.2.1 — Kestrel's first operating year.

1. **Setup.** Revenue USD 12,000,000; cash operating costs USD 4,500,000; plant USD 60,000,000 depreciated straight-line over 25 years; senior interest USD 2,520,000 (Domain 3's year-one figure); tax 20 %.
2. **Formula.** $\text{EBITDA} = \text{revenue} - \text{cash operating costs}$; $\text{EBIT} = \text{EBITDA} - \text{depreciation}$; profit before tax = $\text{EBIT} - \text{interest}$; net income = $\text{PBT} - \text{tax}$. Depreciation = $(\text{cost} - \text{residual}) / \text{useful life}$.
3. **Substitution.** $\text{EBITDA} = 12,000,000 - 4,500,000$; depreciation = $60,000,000 / 25$; $\text{EBIT} = 7,500,000 - 2,400,000$; $\text{PBT} = 5,100,000 - 2,520,000$; tax = $2,580,000 \times 0.20$.
4. **Result.**

Line	USD
Revenue	12,000,000
Cash operating costs	(4,500,000)
EBITDA	7,500,000
Depreciation	(2,400,000)
EBIT	5,100,000
Interest	(2,520,000)
Profit before tax	2,580,000
Tax at 20 %	(516,000)
Net income	2,064,000

1. **Interpretation.** Four layers, four different questions. **EBITDA** approximates the cash the operation generates before financing, tax and the accounting for past capital spend — which is why lenders start there (Domain 10). **EBIT** charges the asset's consumption, so it measures operating performance including capital intensity. **PBT** is after the cost of the capital structure. **Net income** is the shareholders' accounting return — and note it is USD 2,064,000 while **EBITDA** is USD 7,500,000: on a capital-intensive, levered project the gap between the two is mostly depreciation and interest, and confusing them is the commonest error in project financial conversation.

2.2.2 The balance sheet

What it answers: what does the entity own and owe at a point in time? For an SPV the structure is unusually clean — one asset of consequence and one financing structure:

	USD
Plant, net (60,000,000 – 2,400,000 depreciation)	57,600,000
Receivables	900,000
Cash	balancing
Total assets	
Payables	300,000
Senior debt (42,000,000 – 2,489,635 year-one principal)	39,510,365
Equity (contributed + retained)	balancing

Two project-specific points. **The asset is consumed on paper while it produces cash** — depreciation reduces the carrying amount without any payment. And **the debt balance falls by principal only**: of Kestrel's USD 5,009,635 instalment, USD 2,520,000 is interest (an expense) and **USD 2,489,635 is principal** (a balance-sheet movement, not an expense) — exactly Domain 3's schedule. That split is why debt service never appears as a single line in the income statement, and why a reader who looks only at profit cannot see whether the loan is being repaid.

2.2.3 The cash-flow statement

What it answers: where did cash come from and go? Three sections: **operating** (the trading cycle), **investing** (asset purchases and disposals), **financing** (debt drawn and repaid, equity contributed, distributions paid). The indirect method — the one a project leader will usually meet — starts from profit and undoes the accruals:

```

Net income
+ non-cash charges (depreciation, amortisation, provisions)
- increases in receivables and inventory      (cash absorbed)
+ increases in payables                      (cash released)
= operating cash flow

```

2.2.4 Articulation demonstrated

WORKED EXAMPLE

Worked example 2.2.4 — from profit to cash, and proving it ties.

1. **Setup.** Kestrel's income statement above, plus the balance-sheet movements: receivables rose **USD 900,000**, payables rose **USD 300,000**. Derive operating cash flow.
2. **Formula.** Operating cash = net income + depreciation – Δreceivables + Δpayables.
3. **Substitution.** $2,064,000 + 2,400,000 - 900,000 + 300,000$.
4. **Result. Operating cash flow USD 3,864,000** — against net income of USD 2,064,000. The reconciliation: depreciation adds back **+2,400,000** (a charge that moved no cash), working capital absorbs **–600,000** net.
5. **Interpretation.** Read the bridge in both directions. Profit understates the period's cash by the depreciation of an asset paid for years ago; working capital takes back 600,000 of it to fund growth in the trading cycle. Both facts are invisible in the income statement and decisive for a lender. Note also what operating cash flow is **not**: it is before debt principal (a financing flow) and before capex — so a project can show positive operating cash and still fail to cover its obligations. Domain 10's coverage ratios exist precisely to test the thing this statement does not.

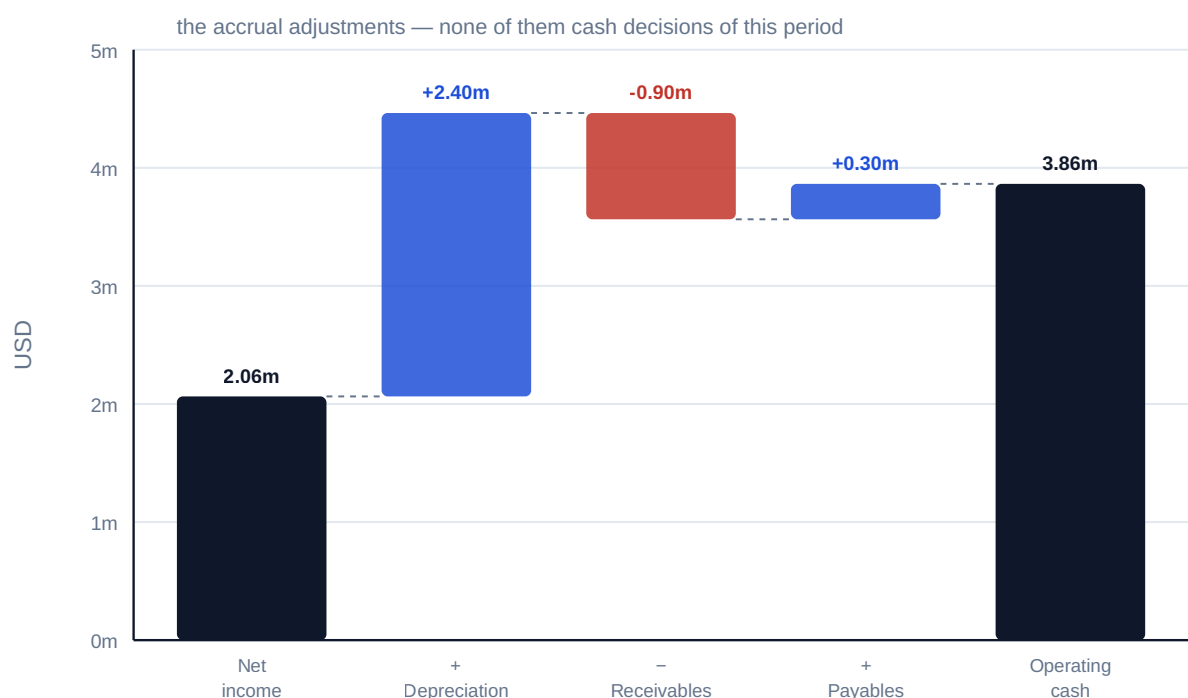


Fig 2.2.1 — Kestrel's accrual-to-cash bridge

■ KEY TERMS — KA 2.2

Term	Meaning
EBITDA	Earnings before interest, tax, depreciation and amortisation.
EBIT	Operating profit after depreciation; performance including capital consumption.
Depreciation	(cost – residual)/useful life; a non-cash charge for asset consumption.
Indirect method	Deriving operating cash flow from profit by undoing accruals.
Working-capital movement	Change in receivables, inventory and payables; absorbs or releases cash.
Principal versus interest	Principal is a balance-sheet movement; only interest is an expense.

■ SAMPLE MCQS — KA 2.2

MCQ 2.2-A [2.2.1 · Application] Revenue 12,000,000; cash operating costs 4,500,000; depreciation 2,400,000; interest 2,520,000; tax 20 %. Net income is: - A. USD 2,580,000 - B. USD 2,064,000 - C. USD 4,080,000 - D. USD 7,500,000

Rationale: $PBT\ 2,580,000 \times (1 - 0.20) = 2,064,000$. A is PBT before tax; C taxes EBIT instead of PBT; D is EBITDA.

MCQ 2.2-B [2.2.4 · Application] Net income 2,064,000; depreciation 2,400,000; receivables +900,000; payables +300,000. Operating cash flow is: - A. USD 4,464,000 - B. USD 3,864,000 - C. USD 3,264,000 - D. USD 2,064,000

Rationale: $2,064,000 + 2,400,000 - 900,000 + 300,000 = 3,864,000$. A omits the working-capital movements; C subtracts the payables increase instead of adding it (supplier credit is a cash source); D stops at profit.

MCQ 2.2-C [2.2.2 · Analysis] Kestrel's annual instalment is 5,009,635, of which 2,520,000 is interest. The income statement expense and the balance-sheet effect are: - A. expense 5,009,635; debt falls by 5,009,635 - B. expense 2,520,000; debt falls by 2,489,635 - C. expense 2,489,635; debt falls by 2,520,000 - D. expense 5,009,635; debt unchanged

Rationale: Only interest is an expense; principal is a balance-sheet movement. A expenses the whole instalment (the classic error), C reverses the two components, D ignores repayment.

MCQ 2.2-D [2.2.3 · Recall] Repayment of debt principal appears in the cash-flow statement under: - A. operating activities - B. investing activities - C. financing activities - D. it does not appear, being a balance-sheet movement

Rationale: Principal flows are financing. D confuses the income statement's silence on principal with absence from the cash-flow statement, where every cash movement appears.

■ SELF-CHECK — KA 2.2

1. Why is **EBITDA** USD 7,500,000 while net income is USD 2,064,000? — Depreciation, interest and tax lie between them; on a capital-intensive levered project that gap is structural.
2. State the accrual-to-cash bridge for Kestrel. — $2,064,000 + 2,400,000 \text{ depreciation} - 900,000 \text{ receivables} + 300,000 \text{ payables} = 3,864,000$.
3. What obligations does operating cash flow not cover? — Debt principal and capex; hence Domain 10's coverage ratios.

KNOWLEDGE AREA 2.3

Project-relevant treatments

Topics: 2.3.1 working capital · 2.3.2 revenue and cost recognition · 2.3.3 capital versus operating expenditure · 2.3.4 provisions and contingencies.

2.3.1 Working capital and why lenders care

Definition. Working capital is the cash tied up in the trading cycle — receivables plus inventory less payables. Growth in it **consumes** cash; reduction **releases** it. For a project, the dominant driver is the gap between doing work and being paid for it, which is why payment terms are a financing decision (Domain 1's cash discipline; Domain 14's drawdowns).

WORKED EXAMPLE**Worked example 2.3.1 — what working capital does to a coverage ratio.**

1. **Setup.** Kestrel's **EBITDA** USD 7,500,000; tax USD 516,000; the net working-capital increase of USD 600,000 from KA 2.2.4. Annual debt service USD 5,009,635 (Domain 3). Compute the **DSCR** — Domain 10's central ratio — first ignoring working capital, then including it.
2. **Formula.** $CFADS = EBITDA - \text{tax} - \Delta \text{working capital}$; $DSCR = CFADS \div \text{debt service}$.
3. **Substitution.** Ignoring WC: $7,500,000 - 516,000 = 6,984,000$; $\div 5,009,635$. Including WC: $6,984,000 - 600,000 = 6,384,000$; $\div 5,009,635$.
4. **Result.** **DSCR 1.39** ignoring working capital; **1.27** including it — a fall of **0.12** from one balance-sheet movement.
5. **Interpretation.** Twelve basis points of coverage may decide whether a covenant holds (typical senior covenants sit at 1.20–1.30, so this project is comfortable at 1.39 and much closer to the line at 1.27). The lesson is definitional rather than arithmetical: **CFADS is a defined term in the finance documents, and whether it is struck before or after working-capital movements changes the ratio it produces.** A leader who quotes a **DSCR** without knowing its **CFADS** definition is quoting an opinion. Domain 10 builds the full machinery; Domain 13's model audit checks that the model implements the documented definition.

2.3.2 Revenue and cost recognition

The principle. Revenue is recognised as performance occurs — when control of the promised goods or services transfers to the customer — not when the invoice is raised or the cash arrives. For long-duration work this means recognising **over time** as the obligation is satisfied, which requires a defensible measure of progress. IFRS 15 is the reference framework, described here in principle only.

Measuring progress uses either **input** methods (costs incurred relative to total expected costs — the familiar percentage-of-completion approach) or **output** methods (units delivered, milestones surveyed). The choice matters and is not free: an input measure can be distorted by inefficiency (spending more "earns" more revenue) and an output measure by lumpy deliverables. This is the same measurement-integrity problem the delivery book handles as earned value (PML-AI, Domain 7, KA 7.3.1) — and the two disciplines should use the same progress evidence, because a project claiming 60 % complete for revenue and 48 % for earned value has a story to explain.

Costs follow performance symmetrically: costs of fulfilling the obligation are expensed as incurred, certain fulfilment costs may be capitalised, and **expected losses are recognised immediately and in full** the moment a contract is expected to be loss-making — a deliberate asymmetry that stops a known loss being spread quietly across future periods.

2.3.3 Capital versus operating expenditure

The distinction. **Capital expenditure (capex)** creates or enhances an asset with benefits beyond the current period; it is capitalised to the balance sheet and depreciated over its useful life. **Operating expenditure (opex)** is consumed in the period and expensed immediately. The same cash outflow, classified differently, produces very different profit.

WORKED EXAMPLE**Worked example 2.3.3 — the same USD 1,200,000, two treatments.**

1. **Setup.** Kestrel spends USD 1,200,000 on a control-system overhaul. If it extends the asset's capability it is capex, depreciated over 10 years; if it restores existing performance it is maintenance opex.
2. **Formula.** Capex year-one charge = spend ÷ useful life. Opex year-one charge = full spend.
3. **Substitution.** Capex: $1,200,000/10 = 120,000$. Opex: $1,200,000$.
4. **Result.** Year-one profit is **USD 1,080,000 lower** under the opex treatment. **Cash is identical in both cases** — USD 1,200,000 leaves the account either way.
5. **Interpretation.** This is the clearest demonstration in the domain that accounting choice moves reported performance without moving economics, and it cuts both ways. Capitalising flatters current profit and burdens future periods with depreciation; it also inflates the asset base against which returns are measured. Because the classification is judgment applied to facts — does this enhance or merely restore? — it is a standing area of audit attention, and a leader should expect to justify it rather than assert it. Note the covenant consequence: profit-based covenants respond to the choice while cash-based ones (**DSCR**) do not, which is part of why lenders prefer cash-based tests (Domain 10).

2.3.4 Provisions and contingencies

Definitions. A **provision** is a liability of uncertain timing or amount, recognised when a present obligation exists from a past event, settlement is probable, and a reliable estimate can be made (IAS 37 is the reference framework, in principle). A **contingent liability** fails one of those tests — typically because settlement is only possible rather than probable — and is **disclosed, not recognised**. A **contingent asset** is treated still more cautiously: disclosed when probable, recognised only when virtually certain, an asymmetry that deliberately resists optimism.

Project-relevant instances: **decommissioning and site-restoration obligations** (recognised at the present value of the expected cost when the obligation arises — often at construction, decades before the spend, and a major balance-sheet item for energy and resources projects); **warranty and defect obligations**; **onerous contracts** (the loss recognised in full, per 2.3.2); and **disputed claims**, where the provision/disclosure boundary is genuinely contested and legal advice governs. The leader's discipline here is narrow and important: **a provision is not a reserve to be created in good years and released in bad ones** — that is earnings management, and the recognition tests exist to prevent it.

AI in this KA

These four treatments are exactly where AI assistance is least reliable, because each turns on judgment applied to specific facts: is this capex or maintenance, is settlement probable, does control transfer over time. A model will produce a confident answer that reads like a conclusion and is actually a summary of how similar questions are usually answered. The governed position: use AI to marshal the facts, locate the relevant framework and draft the argument on both sides; never to reach the conclusion. Conclusions on recognition and measurement belong to the entity's finance function and auditors, and jurisdiction-specific treatment to qualified advisers — the boundary this book applies to itself (Domain 1, KA 1.3.1).

■ KEY TERMS — KA 2.3

Term	Meaning
Working capital	Receivables + inventory – payables; growth consumes cash.
CFADS	Cash flow available for debt service — a defined term whose definition changes the ratio.
Input / output progress measures	Cost-based vs delivery-based measures of performance to date.
Onerous contract	An expected-loss contract; the loss is recognised immediately and in full.
Capex / opex	Capitalised and depreciated vs expensed in the period; same cash, different profit.
Provision / contingent liability	Recognised (present obligation, probable, estimable) vs disclosed.

■ SAMPLE MCQS — KA 2.3

MCQ 2.3-A [2.3.1 · Application] EBITDA 7,500,000; tax 516,000; working-capital increase 600,000; debt service 5,009,635. **DSCR** including the working-capital movement is: - A. 1.39 - B. 1.27 - C. 1.50 - D. 1.20

Rationale: $CFADS = 7,500,000 - 516,000 - 600,000 = 6,384,000$; $\div 5,009,635 = 1.27$. A excludes the working-capital movement (the definitional point of the example); C ignores tax as well; D is a typical covenant threshold, not this calculation.

MCQ 2.3-B [2.3.3 · Application] USD 1,200,000 is spent on an overhaul. Capitalised over 10 years versus expensed immediately, the year-one differences are: - A. profit lower by 1,200,000 if capitalised; cash differs - B. profit lower by 1,080,000 if expensed; cash identical - C. profit identical; cash lower by 1,080,000 if expensed - D. profit lower by 120,000 if expensed; cash identical

Rationale: Expensing charges 1,200,000 against capitalising's 120,000 — a 1,080,000 difference — and the cash outflow is the same either way. A inverts which treatment charges more; C confuses which statement is affected; D states the capitalised charge as the difference.

MCQ 2.3-C [2.3.4 · Analysis] A contractor faces a claim it considers possible but not probable, with a reliably estimable amount. The treatment is: - A. recognise a provision, since the amount is estimable - B. disclose as a contingent liability; recognition requires probable settlement - C. no disclosure, since settlement is not probable - D. recognise a contingent asset

Rationale: Estimability alone is insufficient — probability of settlement is the failed test, so disclosure rather than recognition (2.3.4). C hides information users need; D reverses the direction.

MCQ 2.3-D [2.3.2 · Analysis] A contractor recognises revenue on 60 % completion using a cost-input measure while its earned-value system reports 48 % complete. The soundest reading is: - A. no issue — the two systems serve different purposes - B. the divergence needs explaining: an input measure inflated by inefficiency can recognise revenue ahead of performance - C. the earned-value figure must be wrong - D. revenue should be restated to 48 % automatically

Rationale: Cost-input measures reward spending, so inefficiency can raise apparent progress (2.3.2) — the gap is a signal to investigate, not to dismiss (A) or resolve by assumption (C, D).

■ SELF-CHECK — KA 2.3

1. Why can two projects with identical economics report different **DSCRs**? — Because **CFADS** is a defined term; its definition (e.g. before or after working capital) changes the ratio.

2. What does the capex/opex choice change, and what does it not? — Reported profit and the asset base; not cash.
3. When is a provision recognised rather than disclosed? — Present obligation from a past event, probable settlement, reliable estimate.

KNOWLEDGE AREA 2.4

Ratio interpretation and project interfaces

Topics: 2.4.1 the ratio families · 2.4.2 interest cover and the leverage view · 2.4.3 project systems and corporate reporting.

2.4.1 The ratio families

Ratios are comparisons, and their only value is in what they are compared against — the same entity over time, or a genuine peer on the same policies (KA 2.1.2's warning). Four families:

Family	Asks	Examples
Liquidity	Can it pay what falls due soon?	Current ratio, quick ratio
Leverage	How much of the funding is debt?	Debt/equity, debt/EBITDA
Coverage	Can earnings or cash service the debt?	Interest cover, DSCR (Domain 10)
Return	What is earned on the capital used?	Return on equity, return on capital employed

For project finance the **coverage** family dominates, because a ring-fenced SPV's whole credit case is whether its cash flow services its debt (Domain 1, KA 1.1.2).

2.4.2 Interest cover and the leverage view

WORKED EXAMPLE

Worked example 2.4.2 — Kestrel's cover and gearing.

1. **Setup.** EBIT USD 5,100,000; interest USD 2,520,000; senior debt at year end USD 39,510,365; EBITDA USD 7,500,000.
2. **Formula.** Interest cover = $\text{EBIT} \div \text{interest}$. Debt/EBITDA = $\text{debt} \div \text{EBITDA}$.
3. **Substitution.** $5,100,000 / 2,520,000$; $39,510,365 / 7,500,000$.
4. **Result.** Interest cover **2.02×**; debt/EBITDA **5.27×**.
5. **Interpretation.** Both are true and they point in different directions, which is the point of reading a set. Cover of 2.02× says earnings comfortably absorb the interest charge; debt of 5.27× EBITDA says the balance sheet is heavily geared — normal for contracted infrastructure and alarming for a merchant business, because what makes high leverage tolerable is **revenue certainty**, not the ratio itself (Domain 7's revenue models; Domain 11's risk allocation). Note too that interest cover is an accrual measure and ignores principal entirely: Kestrel must also find USD 2,489,635 of principal, which is why DSCR (1.27 including working capital, 2.3.1) is the ratio a lender actually covenants.

2.4.3 Project systems and corporate reporting

A project's cost system and the corporate accounts describe the same money in different languages, and the interfaces are where reconciliation errors and disputes live. The four that matter:

- **Commitments versus actuals.** A purchase order commits funds; accounting recognises cost on delivery or performance. Project systems track both; the ledger recognises one (PML-AI, Domain 7, KA 7.2.1).
- **Accruals at period end.** Work received but not invoiced must reach the ledger, or cost performance flatters and then lurches — the same defect PML-AI diagnoses as a stepped [CPI](#).
- **Capitalisation boundaries.** Which project costs form part of the asset (and from what date capitalisation begins and ends) determines both the depreciation base and reported profit (2.3.3). Borrowing costs during construction are a specific instance — capitalised into the asset while it is being built, expensed thereafter.
- **Cut-off and period discipline.** A cost is in one period only. Projects run continuously and ledgers close monthly; every reconciliation dispute is ultimately a cut-off question.

The leader's obligation is not to run these reconciliations but to insist they exist and to know which number is being quoted. "The project has spent USD 40 million" can mean committed, incurred, invoiced, paid or capitalised — five different figures, all defensible, differing by material amounts.

■ KEY TERMS — KA 2.4

Term	Meaning
Interest cover	$\text{EBIT} \div \text{interest}$; an accrual coverage measure that ignores principal.
Debt/EBITDA	A leverage measure; tolerable level depends on revenue certainty.
Capitalisation boundary	Which costs and which dates form part of the asset.
Cut-off	Assigning a transaction to exactly one period.
Commitment vs actual vs paid	Distinct measures of "spend" that must never be conflated.

■ SAMPLE MCQS — KA 2.4

MCQ 2.4-A [2.4.2 · Application] EBIT 5,100,000 and interest 2,520,000. Interest cover is: - A. 1.27× - B. 2.02× - C. 2.98× - D. 0.49×

Rationale: $5,100,000 / 2,520,000 = 2.02$. A is the [DSCR](#) from 2.3.1; C uses [EBITDA](#) in the numerator; D inverts the ratio.

MCQ 2.4-B [2.4.2 · Analysis] A project shows interest cover 2.02× and debt/EBITDA 5.27×. The soundest interpretation is: - A. the ratios contradict each other, so one must be wrong - B. earnings service the interest comfortably while leverage is high — tolerable given contracted revenue, but dependent on that certainty - C. the project is over-leveraged regardless of revenue structure - D. interest cover is the only relevant measure for a lender

Rationale: The two measure different things and both are true (2.4.2); what makes high leverage acceptable is revenue certainty. D ignores principal, which is why [DSCR](#) is covenanted.

MCQ 2.4-C [2.4.3 · Analysis] A sponsor asks "how much has the project spent?". The professional response is: - A. quote the paid figure, as it is the most conservative - B. ask which measure is meant — committed, incurred, invoiced, paid or capitalised — since they differ materially and all are

defensible - C. quote the committed figure, as it is the most complete - D. quote the capitalised figure, since it appears in the accounts

Rationale: Five defensible figures exist (2.4.3); answering without establishing which one is meant guarantees a later dispute. Each of A, C and D picks one arbitrarily.

■ SELF-CHECK — KA 2.4

1. Why does project finance emphasise coverage over return ratios? — A ring-fenced SPV's credit case is whether its cash services its debt.
2. What does interest cover ignore? — Principal repayment; hence [DSCR](#).
3. Name the five meanings of "spend". — Committed, incurred, invoiced, paid, capitalised.

— Advanced topics — Domain 2

2.A.1 Deferred tax, in principle

Accounting profit and taxable profit differ — most commonly because tax depreciation (capital allowances) runs on a different profile from accounting depreciation. Where the difference is **temporary**, deferred tax recognises the future consequence: accelerated tax depreciation reduces tax now and creates a **deferred tax liability** that unwinds as the difference reverses. For project models the practical significance is that **cash tax and accounting tax are different lines with different timing**, and it is cash tax that enters [CFADS](#) (Domain 6's model, Domain 10's ratios). Modelling accounting tax as if it were cash tax is a standard model-audit finding.

2.A.2 Leases and off-balance-sheet intuitions

Under current thinking a lessee generally recognises a right-of-use asset and a lease liability, so the older intuition that operating leases keep obligations off the balance sheet no longer holds (IFRS 16 is the reference framework, in principle). Two consequences for a finance leader: leverage ratios computed across periods spanning the change are not comparable, and covenant definitions written before it may capture or exclude lease liabilities in ways nobody intended — a live reason to read the definitions in finance documents rather than assume them.

2.A.3 The reviewer's statement eye

Invariants to test on any statement set before relying on it: the balance sheet balances; closing cash on the cash-flow statement equals balance-sheet cash; closing equity equals opening plus profit less distributions plus contributions; depreciation in the cash-flow statement equals the income-statement charge; the movement in debt equals drawings less principal repaid; principal appears in financing and interest in operating (or as disclosed); working-capital movements reconcile to balance-sheet deltas; and any ratio quoted can be recomputed from the face of the statements. A set that fails any of these has an error, an omission, or a policy that needs explaining — and the failure point localises it.

— Industry variations — Domain 2

- **Energy and resources.** Decommissioning provisions are first-order balance-sheet items, recognised decades before the cash flows; commodity revenue makes recognition timing and hedge accounting material.
- **Transport concessions and PPPs.** The central question is what the operator actually holds — a financial asset (an unconditional right to cash from the grantor), an intangible right to charge users, or a mixture — and the answer changes the whole statement profile for identical economics. Framework treatment is specialised and advice-led.
- **Water and regulated utilities.** Regulatory asset bases and their depreciation profiles may diverge from statutory accounting; two "asset values" coexist and must never be conflated.
- **Digital infrastructure.** Shorter useful lives and heavy refresh capex make the capex/opex boundary (2.3.3) a recurring judgment with large profit consequences.
- **Construction and EPC.** Over-time revenue recognition and onerous-contract provisions are the operative treatments, and the input-versus-output progress choice (2.3.2) is where accounting and project controls must agree or explain.

— Case study — Domain 2: the profitable year that nearly broke a covenant (water)

Situation. Kestrel Water SPC's first operating year closes on the figures above: net income USD 2,064,000, [EBITDA](#) USD 7,500,000 — a good year by any account. The finance director's draft lender report quotes [DSCR](#) 1.39 and describes headroom as comfortable against the facility's 1.25 covenant.

The problem. The facility's definition of [CFADS](#) is struck **after** movements in working capital. Kestrel's receivables had grown USD 900,000 as the offtaker's payment process settled into a slower rhythm than modelled, against a USD 300,000 rise in payables — a net USD 600,000 absorbed. On the documented definition, [CFADS](#) is USD 6,384,000 and [DSCR](#) is 1.27, not 1.39. Headroom against the 1.25 covenant is USD 0.02 of ratio — roughly **USD 100,000 of cash** — not the comfortable margin reported.

What was done. The report was corrected before issue. More consequentially, the near-miss changed three things: collections became a monitored operational metric with a named owner (not a finance afterthought); the model's working-capital assumptions were re-based on nine months of actual collection behaviour rather than the financial-close assumption; and the treasury team sized a working-capital facility as a liquidity buffer. The following year's [DSCR](#) came in at 1.41 on the documented definition.

What the domain teaches here. The arithmetic here is trivial; the professional content is definitional. A ratio is only as good as the defined term inside it, and the definition lives in the finance documents, not in convention. It also shows the accrual/cash divergence of KA 2.1.1 doing real damage — a genuinely profitable year came within USD 100,000 of a covenant breach because of a balance-sheet movement no one was watching.

— Case study B — Domain 2: capitalised into a better-looking year (digital infrastructure)

Situation. A data-centre operator overhauled cooling across three sites for USD 9,000,000, capitalised as an enhancement and depreciated over 12 years — a year-one charge of USD 750,000 rather than USD 9,000,000, lifting reported profit by USD 8,250,000 relative to expensing it.

What happened. The auditors challenged the classification: on inspection, roughly two-thirds of the spend restored the original design capacity rather than extending it, which is maintenance. The restatement moved USD 6,000,000 into operating expense, turned a reported profit into a loss, and breached a profit-based covenant in a holding-company facility. No cash flow changed at any point, and the project's **DSCR** — a cash-based test — was unaffected throughout.

What the domain teaches here. Accounting classification is judgment applied to facts, and it is auditable. The wider lesson is why lenders to projects prefer cash-based covenants: the **DSCR** was indifferent to a classification argument that flipped the profit-based test from comfortable to breached. A leader should know which of their covenants are exposed to accounting judgment and which are not.

— Executive perspective — Domain 2

What a project finance director cannot delegate in this domain:

- **The definitions.** **CFADS**, **EBITDA**, "net debt", "spend" — the director asks what the defined term is in the documents before quoting any ratio built on it (Case study A).
- **The accrual/cash bridge.** Being able to explain, unprompted, why profit and cash differ this period — and what is absorbing the difference.
- **The policy exposures.** Which covenants can be moved by an accounting judgment (capex/opex, revenue timing, provisions) and which cannot.
- **Working capital as an operational matter.** Collections and payment terms are cash decisions with covenant consequences, owned by named people, not finance hygiene.
- **The interface discipline.** Insisting project and ledger reconcile, and never letting the five meanings of "spend" circulate interchangeably.

— Calculation exercises — Domain 2

Exercise 2.1 Revenue 15,000,000; cash operating costs 5,800,000; asset 75,000,000 depreciated over 30 years; interest 2,100,000; tax 20 %. Build the income statement to net income. Solution. **EBITDA 9,200,000**; depreciation $75,000,000/30 = 2,500,000$; **EBIT 6,700,000**; **PBT 4,600,000**; tax **920,000**; net income **3,680,000**. Common error: taxing **EBIT** rather than **PBT** (giving 1,340,000 and overstating tax by 420,000).

Exercise 2.2 From Exercise 2.1, receivables rose 1,100,000, inventory rose 200,000 and payables rose 450,000. Compute operating cash flow. Solution. $3,680,000 + 2,500,000 - 1,100,000 - 200,000 + 450,000 = \text{USD } 5,330,000$. Common error: signing payables negative — supplier credit is a cash source.

Exercise 2.3 Using Exercise 2.1–2.2 and annual debt service of 4,400,000, compute **DSCR** both before and after working-capital movements ($CFADS = EBITDA - \text{tax} [- \Delta WC]$). Solution. Before: $(9,200,000 - 920,000)/4,400,000 = 8,280,000/4,400,000 = \mathbf{1.88}$. After: $\Delta WC 1,100,000 + 200,000 - 450,000 = 850,000$; $7,430,000/4,400,000 = \mathbf{1.69}$. Common error: using net income instead of **EBITDA** in **CFADS** (double-counting interest, which debt service already includes).

Exercise 2.4 USD 2,400,000 is spent on plant modification, capitalised over 8 years versus expensed. State the year-one profit difference and the cash difference. Solution. Capitalised charge $2,400,000/8 = \mathbf{300,000}$; expensed **2,400,000**; profit difference **USD 2,100,000**; cash difference **nil**. Common error: assuming a cash difference because the profit effect is large.

— Practitioner's toolkit — Domain 2

Adoption-ready artefacts; adapt headings to your organisation, then keep them stable.

Toolkit 2.T.1 — Defined-terms sheet (one per financing)

For each term used in a covenant or report — **CFADS**, **EBITDA**, net debt, distributable cash, project costs — record: the **document and clause** defining it, the definition in plain words, what is included and excluded (working capital? cash tax or accrued? maintenance capex?), the model line implementing it, and the person who confirmed the match. A ratio quoted without a row here is not reportable (Case study A).

Toolkit 2.T.2 — Accrual-to-cash bridge (standing monthly schedule)

Net income · + depreciation and amortisation · + other non-cash charges (provisions) · – Δreceivables · – Δinventory · + Δpayables · = operating cash flow · – capex · – principal · – distributions · = movement in cash, **tied to the cash balance**. Rule: it is published even in good months, because its purpose is to make divergence visible before it is material.

Toolkit 2.T.3 — Statement-integrity checklist

- [] Balance sheet balances; closing cash ties to the cash-flow statement.
- [] Closing equity = opening + profit – distributions + contributions.
- [] Depreciation in the cash-flow statement equals the income-statement charge.
- [] Debt movement = drawings – principal repaid; only interest is expensed.
- [] Working-capital movements reconcile to balance-sheet deltas.
- [] Every quoted ratio recomputable from the face of the statements, on its defined terms.
- [] Capitalisation boundary and any policy change disclosed and explained.

— Exam preparation — Domain 2

The traps. Expensing the whole debt instalment instead of interest only (MCQ 2.2-C) · taxing **EBIT** rather than **PBT** (Exercise 2.1) · signing payables the wrong way in the cash bridge (Exercise 2.2) · using net income in **CFADS** and double-counting interest (Exercise 2.3) · assuming a cash difference from a capex/opex choice (Exercise 2.4) · quoting a **DSCR** without its **CFADS** definition (2.3.1) · recognising a provision on estimability alone without probability (2.3.4) · treating accounting tax as cash tax (2.A.1) · comparing leverage across a period spanning a policy change (2.A.2).

Reflection questions. 1. For your current financing: what exactly does [CFADS](#) include, and where is that written down? 2. Which of your covenants could be moved by an accounting judgment rather than a change in economics — and who reviews those judgments? 3. When someone last told you what a project had "spent", which of the five measures was it — and did you ask?

— Domain 2 summary

Accrual accounting records effects when they occur and cash accounting records money when it moves; both matter, because covenants are written on each and they diverge in ways that are information rather than noise. Recognition and measurement are governed by tests, and the policies chosen shape reported figures without touching economics — which is why statements are read sceptically and why the three of them, locked together by articulation, are stronger evidence than any one alone. Kestrel's first year demonstrates the machinery end to end: [EBITDA](#) 7,500,000 descending through depreciation, interest and tax to net income 2,064,000, then bridged back to operating cash flow of 3,864,000 by adding non-cash depreciation and deducting the 600,000 that working capital absorbed — a bridge that also explains why only interest is an expense while the 2,489,635 of principal is a balance-sheet movement. The project-relevant treatments each carry a professional edge: working capital moved Kestrel's [DSCR](#) from 1.39 to 1.27 on the documented [CFADS](#) definition, within USD 100,000 of a covenant; the capex/opex choice moved a year's profit by 1,080,000 on 1,200,000 of spend while cash was unchanged; revenue recognition follows performance and must agree with the progress evidence delivery uses; and provisions are recognised on tests, never created as reserves. Ratios are comparisons whose value lies in what they are compared against, coverage dominates in project finance, and the five meanings of "spend" must never circulate interchangeably. Domain 3 supplies the discounting these statements are valued with; Domain 6 turns them into a model; Domain 10 turns [CFADS](#) into the covenants a lender actually enforces.

03

DOMAIN 3

Time Value of Money and Financial Mathematics (quantitative flagship)

Group: Foundations (Domain 3 of 4 in Part One). **Target:** ~72 pages. **Binds to:** the PCI Book Pattern Specification and the shared registries ([docs/books/registries/](#)). This domain is the definitive home of the discounting symbols — $PV(x)$, $FV(x)$, $DF(t)$, r , n , i_{nom} , i_{real} , π , annuity payment A — every later domain restates them from here. Because this book is discounting-heavy, PV written bare is reserved for Earned Value contexts only; present value is always written $PV(x)$ or in words. British English; USD (+SAR where useful, indicative $USD\ 1 \approx SAR\ 3.75$).

— Why this domain exists

Every judgment a project finance leader makes — whether an investment is worth making (Domain 4), how much debt a project can carry (Domain 10), what a concession's payment stream is worth (Domain 7), whether a delay destroys value (Domain 8) — reduces at some point to one question: what is money at one date worth at another date? Time value of money (TVM) is the machinery that answers it. This domain builds that machinery from first principles: interest and growth (KA 3.1), the annuity family and loan schedules that debt structures are made of (KA 3.2), and the adjustments — inflation, escalation and currency — that separate a defensible model from a spreadsheet accident (KA 3.3). Nothing in this domain is optional equipment: the financial models of Domain 6 are, in the end, disciplined arrangements of exactly these calculations, and the coverage ratios lenders live by (Domain 10) are discounted cash flows wearing covenants.

Learning objectives. After this domain a candidate can: distinguish simple and compound interest and compute either; move any cash amount across time with $FV(x)$ and $PV(x)$ and read a discount-factor table; value level streams with annuity and perpetuity formulae; build and check a loan schedule (annuity, level-principal and bullet); convert between nominal, periodic and effective rates; keep nominal and real quantities consistent using the Fisher relation; escalate costs and revenues defensibly; state how currency and forward rates enter project cash flows; and apply the governed-AI rule to any machine-produced calculation of these kinds.

The master financing. One fictional project runs through this domain and returns in Domains 4, 6 and 10. **Kestrel Water SPC** is a special-purpose company developing a seawater desalination plant. Its senior lenders offer a **USD 42,000,000** loan repayable over **12 years at 6.0 %** annual interest; the offtaker will pay an **availability payment of USD 5,600,000 per year for 25 years**; Kestrel's board evaluates offers at a discount rate of **8.0 %**. All three numbers are used repeatedly below — by the end of the domain the reader can price every side of Kestrel's deal.

KNOWLEDGE AREA 3.1

Interest and value

Topics: 3.1.1 simple and compound interest · 3.1.2 present and future value · 3.1.3 discount factors.

3.1.1 Simple and compound interest

Definitions. Interest is the price of money over time. Under **simple interest** the charge accrues on the original principal only:

$$FV(x) = x \times (1 + r \times n) \quad \text{— simple interest}$$

Under **compound interest** each period's interest joins the principal and itself earns interest:

$$FV(x) = x \times (1 + r)^n \quad \text{— compound interest}$$

where x is the amount today (currency), r the interest rate per period (ratio) and n the number of periods (count). Project finance is a compound-interest world: loans, discounting, escalation and returns all compound. Simple interest survives only in narrow corners — short-duration instruments, some penalty-interest clauses, and certain Islamic-finance structures that avoid interest altogether and price time differently (Domain 9, KA 9.3).

The principle. Compounding is growth on growth. Its effect looks negligible over one or two periods and decisive over ten: the gap between the two formulae widens geometrically, which is why long-life infrastructure — concessions of 25 to 40 years — is acutely sensitive to the rate used.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Worked example 3.1.1 — the same deposit, two rules.

1. **Setup.** USD 100,000 is placed for 3 years at 8.0 % per year. Compare simple and compound growth.
2. **Formula.** Simple: $FV(x) = x(1 + rn)$. Compound: $FV(x) = x(1 + r)^n$, with $x = 100,000$, $r = 0.08$, $n = 3$.
3. **Substitution.** Simple: $100,000 \times (1 + 0.08 \times 3) = 100,000 \times 1.24$. Compound: $100,000 \times 1.08^3 = 100,000 \times 1.259712$.
4. **Result.** Simple: **USD 124,000**. Compound: **USD 125,971** (125,971.20 at full precision).
5. **Interpretation.** Three years of compounding adds USD 1,971 over simple interest — under 2 %. Over a 25-year concession life the same 8 % compounds to $1.08^{25} \approx 6.85$ times the principal, while simple interest reaches only 3.0 times. The professional habit this example teaches: never extrapolate a short-horizon intuition to a long-horizon contract.

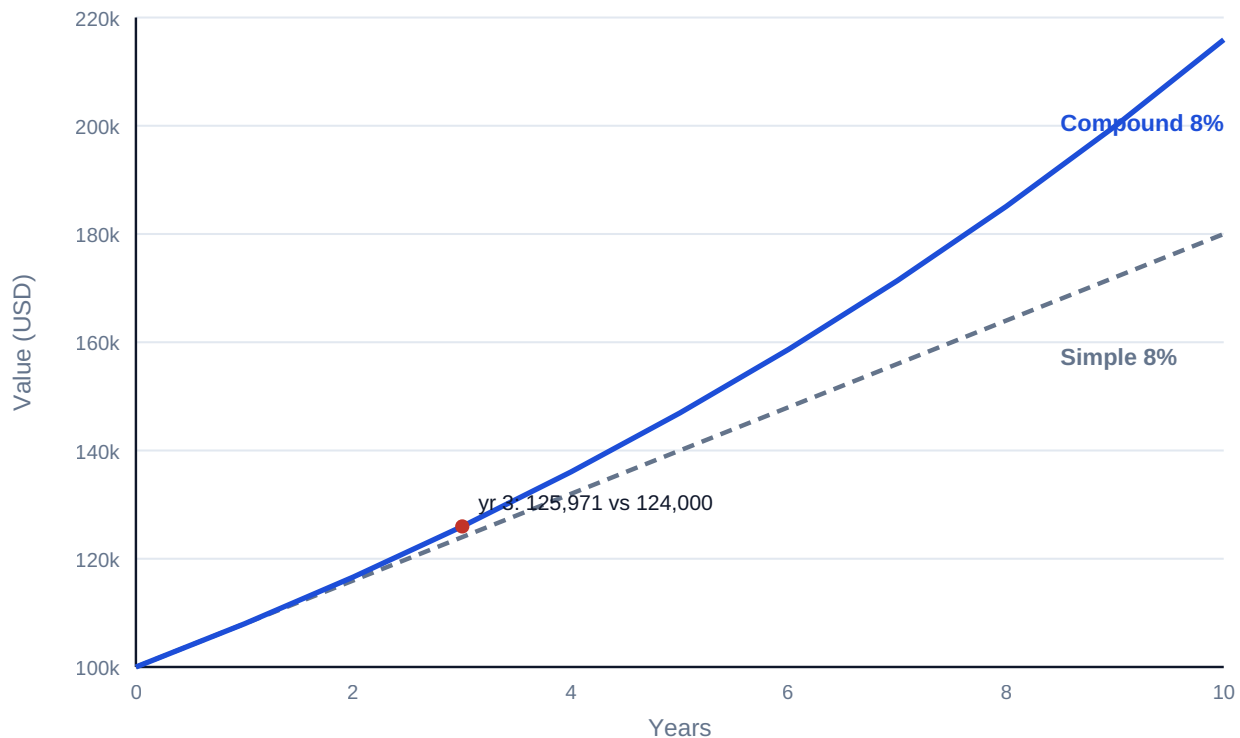


Fig 3.1.1 — Simple versus compound growth of USD 100,000 at 8 %

3.1.2 Present and future value

Definitions. Compounding runs both ways. **Future value** carries an amount forward; **present value** brings a future amount back:

$$FV(x) = x \times (1 + r)^n$$

$$PV(x) = x / (1 + r)^n$$

$PV(x)$ answers the only question a bid evaluation, a settlement offer or a buy-out negotiation really asks: what is that future money worth today, at the return I could otherwise earn? The rate r used in this role is called the **discount rate**; choosing it is a Domain 4 judgment (and, for a levered project, a Domain 9/10 conversation) — this KA takes it as given.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Worked example 3.1.2 — pricing a deferred receipt.

1. **Setup.** Kestrel will receive a USD 500,000 connection rebate exactly 5 years from now. The board discounts at 7.0 % for this risk. What is the rebate worth today?
2. **Formula.** $PV(x) = x / (1 + r)^n$, with $x = 500,000$, $r = 0.07$, $n = 5$.
3. **Substitution.** $PV(x) = 500,000 / 1.07^5 = 500,000 / 1.402552$.
4. **Result.** **USD 356,493** (356,493.09 at full precision; indicatively $\approx$ SAR 1,336,849 at USD 1 $\approx$ SAR 3.75).
5. **Interpretation.** A five-year wait at 7 % costs the rebate just under 29 % of its face value. If a counterparty offered USD 380,000 cash today to extinguish the obligation, Kestrel should accept — and if offered USD 330,000, decline. $PV(x)$ turns "later" into a number that can be compared, which is the whole trade of this profession.

Common pitfall. Discounting with simple interest — $500,000 / (1 + 0.07 \times 5) = 370,370$ — overstates the value by USD 13,877 here. The error grows with horizon and rate; audit any model whose discount factors were "simplified".

3.1.3 Discount factors

Definition. The **discount factor** for period t is the present value of one currency unit received at t :

$$DF(t) = 1 / (1 + r)^t \quad \text{so that} \quad PV(x \text{ at } t) = x \times DF(t)$$

Discount factors are how models industrialise discounting: compute the factor row once, multiply every cash-flow row by it (Domain 6, KA 6.1). They also make review fast — an experienced reviewer reads a factor table the way a scheduler reads float.

At $r = 10\%$:

t (years)	1	2	3	4	5
$DF(t)$	0.9091	0.8264	0.7513	0.6830	0.6209

Two sanity rules a reviewer applies on sight: factors must **decline monotonically**, and each factor must equal the previous factor divided by $(1 + r)$. A factor table that violates either has a hard-coded cell or a broken formula — a Domain 6 model-check classic (KA 6.4).

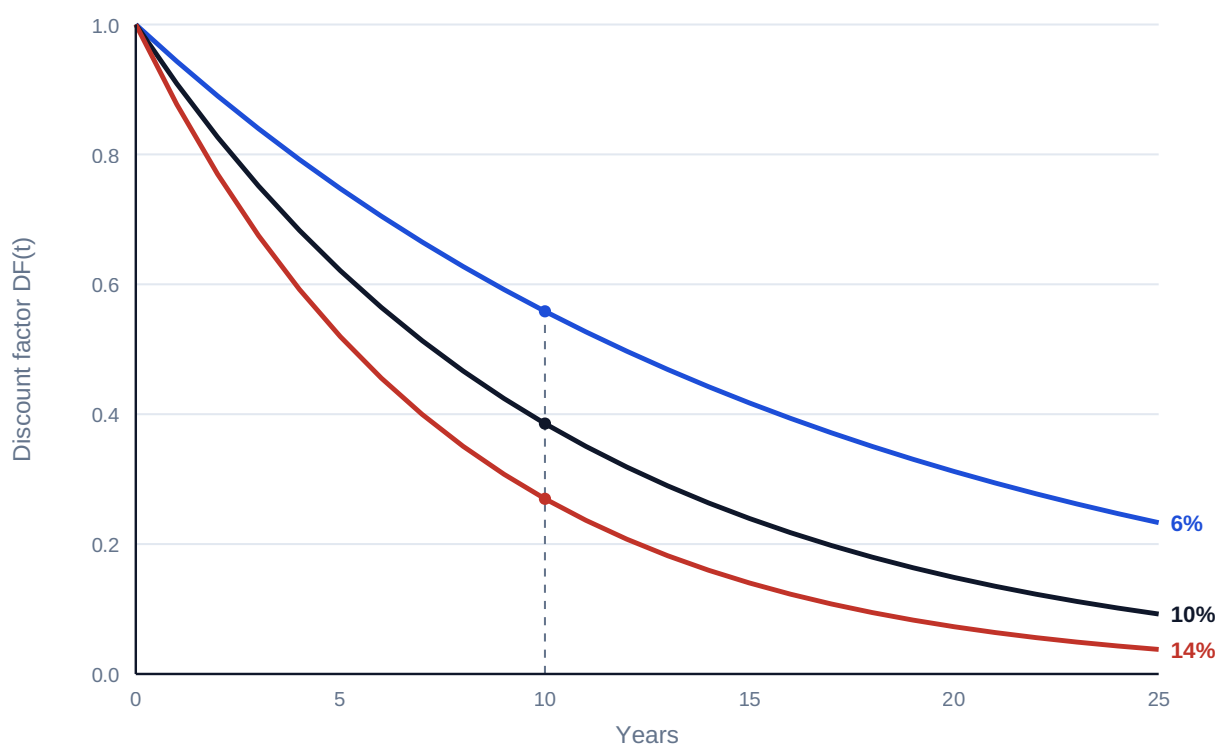


Fig 3.1.2 — Discount-factor curves at 6 %, 10 % and 14 %

Rounding discipline. Factors are displayed to four decimals but **calculations use full precision**. Multiplying a USD 900,000,000 programme cash flow by a four-decimal factor can move results by tens of thousands; the display is for the reader, never for the arithmetic (see the registry's decimal-arithmetic rule).

AI in this KA

Spreadsheet copilots will happily draft TVM formulae, and large-language-model assistants will "explain" a discount factor with perfect fluency and an inverted exponent. The governed position (the PCI principle: **AI proposes; the professional verifies, decides and remains accountable**) is mechanical here because verification is cheap: recompute one factor by hand, check monotonicity, check $DF(1) \times (1+r) = 1$. An AI-drafted factor row that no human recomputed is not a calculation; it is a claim.

■ KEY TERMS — KA 3.1

Term	Meaning
Simple interest	Interest accruing on original principal only: $FV(x) = x(1 + rn)$.
Compound interest	Interest accruing on principal and accumulated interest: $FV(x) = x(1 + r)^n$.
Present value $PV(x)$	Today's worth of a future amount at discount rate r .
Future value $FV(x)$	The compounded worth of an amount at a future date.
Discount rate	The rate r used to move value across time; the required return for the risk.
Discount factor $DF(t)$	$1/(1+r)^t$; the PV of one unit received at t .

■ SAMPLE MCQS — KA 3.1

MCQ 3.1-A [3.1.2 · Application] A payment of USD 500,000 is due in 5 years; the discount rate is 7 %. Its present value is closest to: - A. USD 370,370 - B. USD 356,493 - C. USD 381,448 - D. USD 701,276

Rationale: $500,000 / 1.07^5 = 356,493$. A discounts with simple interest $(1 + 0.35)$; C uses four years instead of five; D compounds forward instead of discounting back.

MCQ 3.1-B [3.1.3 · Application] At a 10 % discount rate, the discount factor for year 3 is: - A. 0.7000 - B. 0.8264 - C. 0.7513 - D. 0.6830

Rationale: $1/1.10^3 = 0.7513$. A subtracts 10 % three times (simple); B is the year-2 factor; D is the year-4 factor — the two most common off-by-one-period errors.

MCQ 3.1-C [3.1.1 · Analysis] A lender quotes 25-year money and a borrower's analyst tests affordability using simple interest "as a conservative shortcut". The analyst's error is that: - A. simple interest overstates the debt cost, so the test is merely too strict - B. compound growth exceeds simple growth over long horizons, so the shortcut materially understates the true accumulation - C. the two methods converge over long horizons, so the shortcut is harmless - D. simple interest cannot be computed for horizons beyond ten years

Rationale: Compounding produces growth on growth: at 8 % over 25 years the compound multiple is ≈ 6.85 versus 3.0 simple — the shortcut is anti-conservative, the opposite of the analyst's claim (so A is wrong); the methods diverge rather than converge (C); D is arithmetic nonsense.

MCQ 3.1-F [3.1.2 · Application] USD 250,000 is invested at 7 % compound for 6 years. Its future value is closest to: - A. USD 355,000 - B. USD 350,638 - C. USD 375,183 - D. USD 166,586

Rationale: $250,000 \times 1.07^6 = 375,183$. A is simple interest $(1 + 0.07 \times 6)$; B compounds only 5 years; D divides instead of multiplying — discounting when the question asks for growth.

MCQ 3.1-D [3.1.3 · Recall] Which statement about discount factors is an invariant a reviewer can test without knowing the project? - A. $DF(t)$ rises when cash flows are contracted - B. $DF(t+1) = DF(t) / (1 + r)$ for every t - C. $DF(t)$ equals $1 - r \times t$ - D. factors below 0.5 indicate an error

Rationale: Each factor is the prior factor discounted one more period — B holds for any r . A confuses risk of flows with the factor row; C is the simple-interest approximation; D is false — any long horizon at a normal rate passes 0.5 (see Fig 3.1.2).

MCQ 3.1-E [3.1.2 · Application] At 9 %, which is worth more today: USD 400,000 in 2 years, or USD 470,000 in 4 years? - A. the 470,000 — larger amounts always win - B. the 400,000: PV 336,672 vs 332,960 - C. the 470,000: PV 395,590 vs 336,672 - D. they are equal at 9 %

Rationale: $400,000/1.09^2 = 336,672$; $470,000/1.09^4 = 332,960$ — the earlier, smaller amount wins by USD 3,712. A ignores discounting entirely; C discounts the 470,000 across only two periods instead of four; D asserts an equality the arithmetic denies.

■ SELF-CHECK — KA 3.1

1. Why must discount factors decline monotonically? — Because $(1+r)^t$ grows with t for any positive r ; a rising factor implies a negative rate or a broken formula.
2. Your model shows $DF(4) = 0.6830$ and $DF(5) = 0.6209$ at 10 %. One cell check confirms both. Which? — $0.6830 / 1.10 = 0.6209$: each factor is the prior factor divided by $(1+r)$.
3. A colleague says "8 % for three years is 24 %". — Only under simple interest; compounded it is $1.08^3 - 1 = 25.97$ %, and the gap widens every further year.

KNOWLEDGE AREA 3.2

Annuities and loan schedules

Topics: 3.2.1 annuities and perpetuities · 3.2.2 loan schedules · 3.2.3 compounding frequency and effective rates.

3.2.1 Annuities and perpetuities

Definitions. An **annuity** is a level stream — the same amount each period for n periods. Project finance is built from annuities and near-annuities: availability payments, capacity charges, lease rentals, O&M fees, debt service. The present value of an ordinary annuity (payments at period-ends) of amount A :

$$PV(\text{annuity}) = A \times AF(r, n) \quad \text{where} \quad AF(r, n) = (1 - (1 + r)^{-n}) / r$$

$AF(r, n)$ is the **annuity factor** — the sum of the discount factors $DF(1) \dots DF(n)$. A **perpetuity** is the limiting case as $n \rightarrow \infty$:

$$PV(\text{perpetuity}) = A / r$$

WORKED EXAMPLE**Worked example 3.2.1 — valuing Kestrel's availability stream.**

1. **Setup.** Kestrel's offtaker will pay USD 3,000,000 per year for 20 years under an early tariff proposal, paid annually in arrears. The board discounts at 9.0 %. Value the stream.
2. **Formula.** $PV = A \times AF(r, n)$, $AF(r, n) = (1 - (1+r)^{-n})/r$, with $A = 3,000,000$, $r = 0.09$, $n = 20$.
3. **Substitution.** $AF(0.09, 20) = (1 - 1.09^{-20})/0.09 = 9.128546$; $PV = 3,000,000 \times 9.128546$.
4. **Result.** **USD 27,385,637** (using the full-precision factor).
5. **Interpretation.** Twenty years of payments are worth barely nine years' worth of face value — discounting at 9 % has priced away more than half the nominal USD 60,000,000 total. Sensitivity: at a 10 % rate the factor falls to 8.513564 and the value to USD 25,540,691 — a 6.7 % value loss for one point of rate, the shape of sensitivity every concession bidder lives with (Domain 7, KA 7.4).

Common pitfall — the rounded factor. Using a four-decimal factor (9.1285) gives USD 27,385,500 — USD 137 adrift here, but scale the stream by 100× and the drift is five figures. Factors are display; arithmetic is full precision (KA 3.1.3).

Timing variants. An **annuity-due** (payments in advance, common in leases and some availability regimes) is worth $(1 + r)$ times the ordinary annuity; a **deferred annuity** starts after a gap and is discounted twice — as a stream, then back across the deferral. Misreading the payment convention in a concession agreement misprices the whole stream by one period's discounting — check the contract, not the habit (Domain 12, KA 12.2).

WORKED EXAMPLE**Worked example 3.2.1b — the lease quoted in advance.**

1. **Setup.** Kestrel's operations base is leased at USD 500,000 per year for 5 years, payable **in advance**. Discount rate 8.0 %. Value the obligation.
2. **Formula.** $PV(\text{due}) = A \times AF(r, n) \times (1 + r)$, with $A = 500,000$, $r = 0.08$, $n = 5$.
3. **Substitution.** $AF(0.08, 5) = 3.992710$; ordinary value $500,000 \times 3.992710 = 1,996,355$; due value $1,996,355 \times 1.08$.
4. **Result.** **USD 2,156,063** (2,156,063.42). The in-advance convention adds USD 159,708 — exactly one period's discounting on the whole stream.
5. **Interpretation.** Eight per cent of the stream's value hangs on one word in the lease. Reading "payable annually in advance" as an ordinary annuity is the commonest annuity mistake in diligence reviews (Domain 13, KA 13.1) — and it always flatters the tenant's model.

WORKED EXAMPLE**Worked example 3.2.1c — the deferred availability stream.**

1. **Setup.** A grantor variant offers Kestrel the same USD 5,600,000 × 25-year availability supplement, but with the **first payment at the end of year 4** (a three-year deferral while the plant ramps up). Discount rate 8.0 %.
2. **Formula.** $PV = A \times AF(r, n) / (1 + r)^d$, $d = 3$ (the stream's own valuation point sits at the end of year 3, one period before its first payment).
3. **Substitution.** $5,600,000 \times 10.674776 = 59,778,747$ (the stream valued at end-year 3); $59,778,747 / 1.08^3 = 59,778,747 / 1.259712$.
4. **Result.** **USD 47,454,296.**
5. **Interpretation.** The three-year wait costs USD 12.3 million — a fifth of the stream's value — which is precisely what the grantor saves by deferring. Any negotiation over payment timing is a negotiation over value at compound rates; Case study A prices the whole family of such trades.

3.2.2 Loan schedules

The three canonical shapes. A loan of principal P over n periods at rate r can be scheduled three ways, and a project finance leader must read all three on sight:

Shape	Rule	Debt-service profile	Where seen
Annuity (equal instalment)	Payment $A = P \times r / (1 - (1+r)^{-n})$ each period	Level total; interest share falls, principal share rises	Most project term loans; mortgages
Level principal	Principal P/n each period + interest on balance	Front-loaded total, declining	Some ECA and development-bank facilities (Domain 9)
Bullet	Interest only; principal entire at maturity	Low until the final balloon	Bonds; mini-perm structures; refinancing plays (Domain 15)

WORKED EXAMPLE**Worked example 3.2.2 — Kestrel's senior loan.**

1. **Setup.** USD 42,000,000, 12 annual instalments, 6.0 % — annuity shape. Find the instalment and build the first three schedule rows.
2. **Formula.** $A = P \times r / (1 - (1+r)^{-n})$, with $P = 42,000,000$, $r = 0.06$, $n = 12$. Each row: interest = opening balance × r ; principal = A – interest; closing = opening – principal.
3. **Substitution.** $A = 42,000,000 \times 0.06 / (1 - 1.06^{-12}) = 42,000,000 / 8.383844$.
4. **Result.** $A =$ **USD 5,009,635** per year (5,009,635.23; indicatively ≈ SAR 18,786,132).
Schedule:

Year	Opening balance	Interest (6 %)	Principal	Closing balance
1	42,000,000	2,520,000	2,489,635	39,510,365
2	39,510,365	2,370,622	2,639,013	36,871,351
3	36,871,351	2,212,281	2,797,354	34,073,997

1. **Interpretation.** The instalment never changes; its composition does — year 1 is 50 % interest, and by the final year almost all principal. Two checks a reviewer runs instantly: the closing balance after year 12 must be exactly zero (a residual means a formula error), and total principal across all rows must equal **P**. This schedule is the direct input to Kestrel's debt service line — and therefore to its DSCR — in Domains 6 and 10.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Worked example 3.2.2b — the same loan, level-principal.

1. **Setup.** Kestrel's ECA co-lender offers the same USD 42,000,000 over 12 years at 6.0 % but on a **level-principal** schedule. Build the first two rows and the final row, and compare lifetime interest across all three shapes.
2. **Formula.** Principal each year $P/n = 42,000,000/12 = 3,500,000$; interest = opening balance $\times 6\%$; total = principal + interest.
3. **Substitution.** Year 1: $3,500,000 + 42,000,000 \times 0.06$. Year 2: $3,500,000 + 38,500,000 \times 0.06$. Year 12: $3,500,000 + 3,500,000 \times 0.06$.
4. **Result.** Year 1 **USD 6,020,000** · year 2 **USD 5,810,000** · year 12 **USD 3,710,000** — a declining profile. Lifetime interest: level-principal **USD 16,380,000** · annuity **USD 18,115,623** · bullet **USD 30,240,000**.
5. **Interpretation.** Level-principal is the cheapest shape in total interest because principal retires fastest — but its year-1 debt service is USD 1,010,365 heavier than the annuity's, exactly when a ramping project is cash-poorest. Shape selection is a cash-timing decision, not a cost minimisation: Domain 10 (KA 10.1) sizes debt against the early-year coverage this choice determines.

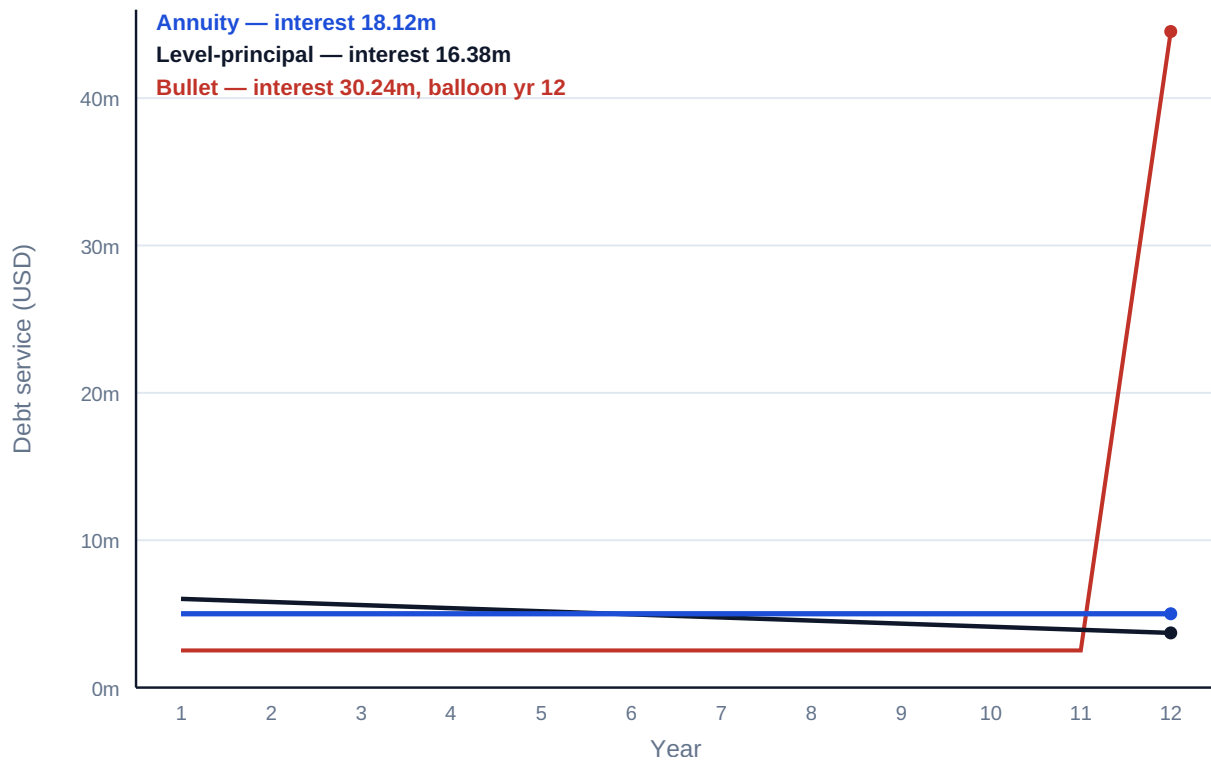


Fig 3.2.2 — Three shapes, one loan: annual debt service under annuity, level-principal and

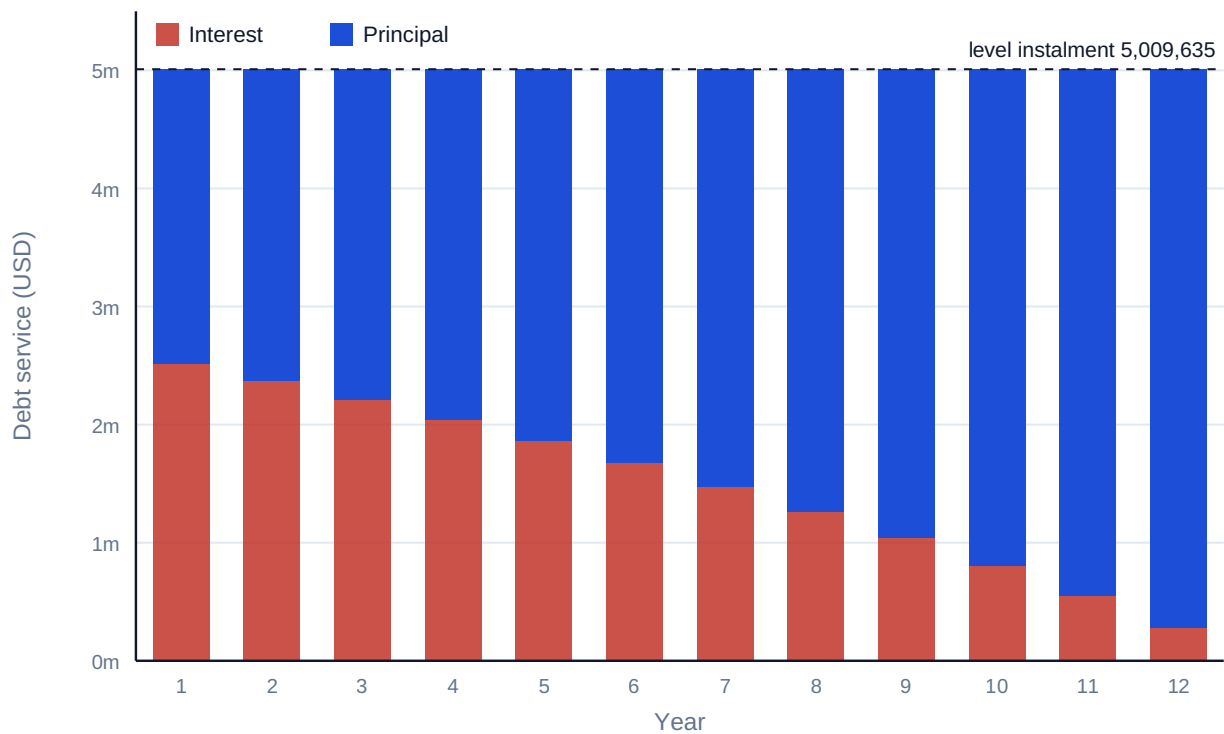


Fig 3.2.1 — Anatomy of an annuity loan: Kestrel's USD 42,000,000, 12 years at 6 %

Common pitfall — the bullet that looks cheap. A bullet's early debt service is a fraction of an annuity's, and a cash-strapped sponsor will feel the temptation. The full price appears at maturity as

refinancing risk — the balloon must be refinanced at whatever the market then charges (Domain 15, KA 15.3). Case study B prices this trade.

3.2.3 Compounding frequency and effective rates

Definitions. A quoted **nominal annual rate** i_{nom} compounded m times per year applies i_{nom}/m per period. The **effective annual rate (EAR)** is the once-a-year rate that produces the same growth:

$$\text{EAR} = (1 + i_{\text{nom}} / m)^m - 1$$

WORKED EXAMPLE

Worked example 3.2.3 — the same 6 %, four ways.

1. **Setup.** A facility is quoted at "6 % nominal". Find the effective annual rate if compounding is annual, semi-annual, quarterly and monthly.
2. **Formula.** $\text{EAR} = (1 + 0.06/m)^m - 1$ for $m = 1, 2, 4, 12$.
3. **Substitution.** $m=4$: $(1 + 0.015)^4 - 1 = 1.061364 - 1$.
4. **Result.** Annual **6.000 %** · semi-annual **6.090 %** · quarterly **6.136 %** · monthly **6.168 %**.
5. **Interpretation.** "Six per cent" is not one price; it is four prices in this example alone, and the differences compound over a 12-year loan. Term sheets are compared on effective rates, never on quoted nominals — and loan models must use the **periodic** rate i_{nom}/m with $n \times m$ periods, not the EAR with n years, or debt service will be misstated (Domain 6, KA 6.3).

AI in this KA

Amortisation is where AI-assisted modelling earns its keep — and where it must be caged. Generating a 360-row monthly schedule is exactly the mechanical work a copilot does well; whether the schedule uses the periodic rate correctly, honours the day-count convention in the actual facility agreement, and zeroes the final balance is exactly what it gets wrong silently. The governed workflow (Domain 6, KA 6.4; Domain 16): AI drafts the schedule; the professional runs the three deterministic checks (final balance zero; Σ principal = P ; payment recomputed independently) before any output leaves the model.

■ KEY TERMS — KA 3.2

Term	Meaning
Annuity / annuity-due	Level periodic stream, in arrears / in advance.
Annuity factor $AF(r, n)$	$(1 - (1+r)^{-n})/r$; PV of 1 per period for n periods.
Perpetuity	Level stream forever; $PV = A/r$.
Annuity, level-principal, bullet	The three canonical loan shapes.
Balloon / refinancing risk	The bullet's maturity principal and the risk of the rate then prevailing.
Nominal rate / EAR	Quoted annual rate with compounding frequency / its once-a-year equivalent.

■ SAMPLE MCQS — KA 3.2

MCQ 3.2-A [3.2.2 · Application] A USD 42,000,000 loan is repaid by 12 equal annual instalments at 6 %. The instalment is closest to: - A. USD 3,500,000 - B. USD 2,520,000 - C. USD 5,009,635 - D. USD 5,706,454

Rationale: $42,000,000 \times 0.06 / (1 - 1.06^{-12}) = 5,009,635$. A divides principal by 12 and ignores interest; B is interest-only on the full balance; D uses a 10-year annuity factor — the wrong-tenor error.

MCQ 3.2-B [3.2.3 · Application] A 6 % nominal rate compounded quarterly has an effective annual rate of: - A. 6.00 % - B. 6.09 % - C. 6.14 % - D. 6.17 %

Rationale: $(1 + 0.015)^4 - 1 = 6.136 \% \approx 6.14 \%$. A is the nominal itself; B is semi-annual compounding; D is monthly — each a frequency misread.

MCQ 3.2-C [3.2.1 · Analysis] Two otherwise identical concession bids value the same 20-year availability stream. Bid X used the full-precision annuity factor; Bid Y rounded the factor to four decimals. The most defensible statement is: - A. the bids differ by an amount that grows with the size of the stream, and only X's practice passes model audit - B. rounding the factor is conservative, so Y understates value and is safer - C. the difference is always immaterial because four decimals is industry standard - D. Y's approach is wrong only if the discount rate exceeds 10 %

Rationale: Factor rounding error scales linearly with the cash flows and has no consistent conservative direction (B, D wrong); materiality depends on scale, not convention (C wrong); model audit standards require full-precision arithmetic with display-only rounding.

MCQ 3.2-F [3.2.1 · Analysis] A wayleave pays USD 800,000 per year; the discount rate is 8 %. Modelling it as a 30-year annuity instead of a perpetuity understates its value by: - A. USD 993,773 — the present value of the post-year-30 tail - B. nothing material — thirty years is effectively forever - C. USD 4,000,000 — one-third of the perpetuity value - D. it overstates value, because perpetuities are riskier

Rationale: Perpetuity $800,000 / 0.08 = 10,000,000$; 30-year annuity $800,000 \times 11.257783 = 9,006,227$; the gap — 9.9 % of value — is the discounted tail. B waves away a million dollars; C invents a fraction; D confuses valuation arithmetic with a risk adjustment that belongs in the rate, not the formula choice.

MCQ 3.2-D [3.2.1 · Application] A 5-year, USD 500,000-per-year lease payable **in advance** is valued at 8 %. Its present value is closest to: - A. USD 1,996,355 - B. USD 2,156,063 - C. USD 2,500,000 - D. USD 1,848,477

Rationale: Annuity-due = ordinary annuity $\times (1+r)$: $500,000 \times 3.992710 \times 1.08 = 2,156,063$. A prices it as an ordinary annuity (the classic misread); C is the undiscounted total; D divides the ordinary value by 1.08 — the adjustment applied backwards.

MCQ 3.2-E [3.2.2 · Analysis] For the same principal, tenor and rate, which repayment shape has the lowest lifetime interest, and why? - A. the annuity — its instalments are level, so interest is averaged down - B. the bullet — deferral shrinks the money's time exposure - C. level-principal — the balance falls fastest, so less principal is outstanding for less time - D. all three are equal because rate and tenor are equal

Rationale: Interest is rate $\times$ outstanding balance $\times$ time; level-principal retires balance fastest (Kestrel: 16.38m vs 18.12m annuity vs 30.24m bullet). A's "averaging" is not a mechanism; B reverses the truth — the bullet maximises exposure; D ignores the balance path entirely.

■ SELF-CHECK — KA 3.2

1. What two instant checks validate any amortising schedule? — Final closing balance exactly zero; total principal equals the original loan.
2. Why is an annuity-due worth $(1+r) \times$ the ordinary annuity? — Every payment arrives one period earlier, so each escapes one period of discounting.
3. A term sheet quotes "5.9 % monthly"; another "6.0 % annual". Which is dearer? — The first: $(1 + 0.059/12)^{12} - 1 = 6.06$ % effective, above 6.00 %.

KNOWLEDGE AREA 3.3

Real-world adjustments: inflation, escalation and currency

Topics: 3.3.1 nominal and real rates · 3.3.2 inflation and escalation · 3.3.3 currency effects · 3.3.4 day-count conventions.

3.3.1 Nominal and real rates — the Fisher relation

Definitions. A **nominal** rate i_{nom} is quoted in money terms; a **real** rate i_{real} is measured in purchasing power, after inflation π . They are linked by the **Fisher relation**:

$$(1 + i_{\text{nom}}) = (1 + i_{\text{real}}) \times (1 + \pi) \quad \text{so} \quad i_{\text{real}} = (1 + i_{\text{nom}})/(1 + \pi) - 1$$

The subtraction shortcut $i_{\text{real}} \approx i_{\text{nom}} - \pi$ is a first-order approximation only — usable for intuition, never for models.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Worked example 3.3.1 — the real cost of Kestrel's equity hurdle.

1. **Setup.** Kestrel's shareholders require a 9.0 % nominal return; inflation is expected at 3.0 %. What real return are they actually demanding?
2. **Formula.** $i_{\text{real}} = (1 + i_{\text{nom}})/(1 + \pi) - 1$, with $i_{\text{nom}} = 0.09$, $\pi = 0.03$.
3. **Substitution.** $i_{\text{real}} = 1.09 / 1.03 - 1 = 1.058252 - 1$.
4. **Result.** **5.83 %** real (5.8252 % at full precision). The subtraction shortcut says 6.00 % — 17 basis points high.
5. **Interpretation.** Seventeen basis points sounds academic until it is applied to a 25-year stream: mispricing the hurdle by that much moves a large concession's value by roughly one and a half years' worth of payments. Models must live entirely in one world — nominal cash flows with nominal rates, or real with real. **Mixing them is the single most common TVM defect found in model audits** (Domain 6, KA 6.4; Domain 13, KA 13.2).

3.3.2 Inflation and escalation

Definitions. **Inflation** is the general price level's drift; **escalation** is the contractual or forecast growth of a specific price — a tariff indexed to CPI, labour rates under a collective agreement, steel under a commodity formula. An amount x escalating at rate e for n periods becomes $x \times (1 + e)^n$. Escalation compounds, exactly like interest — and like interest, it is routinely underestimated over long horizons.

WORKED EXAMPLE**Worked example 3.3.2 — an O&M contract's third-year price.**

1. **Setup.** Kestrel's O&M contract prices year-0 services at USD 10,000,000, escalating 4.0 % annually. What is the year-3 price?
2. **Formula.** $x_n = x_0 \times (1 + e)^n$, with $x_0 = 10,000,000$, $e = 0.04$, $n = 3$.
3. **Substitution.** $10,000,000 \times 1.04^3 = 10,000,000 \times 1.124864$.
4. **Result.** **USD 11,248,640.**
5. **Interpretation.** Simple-escalation thinking says "+12 %" (USD 11,200,000); compounding adds USD 48,640 by year 3 and the gap widens every year after. In a 25-year operating model the compound-vs-simple escalation choice changes lifecycle cost by whole percentage points — Domain 8 (KA 8.2) builds the full escalated cash-flow machinery on this rule.

Indexation discipline. Real contracts escalate on published indices with definitions, lags, caps and floors (Domain 7, KA 7.3; Domain 12). A model's escalation assumptions must cite the contractual index and its mechanics, not a bare percentage — the toolkit's escalation register (3.T.3) exists for exactly this.

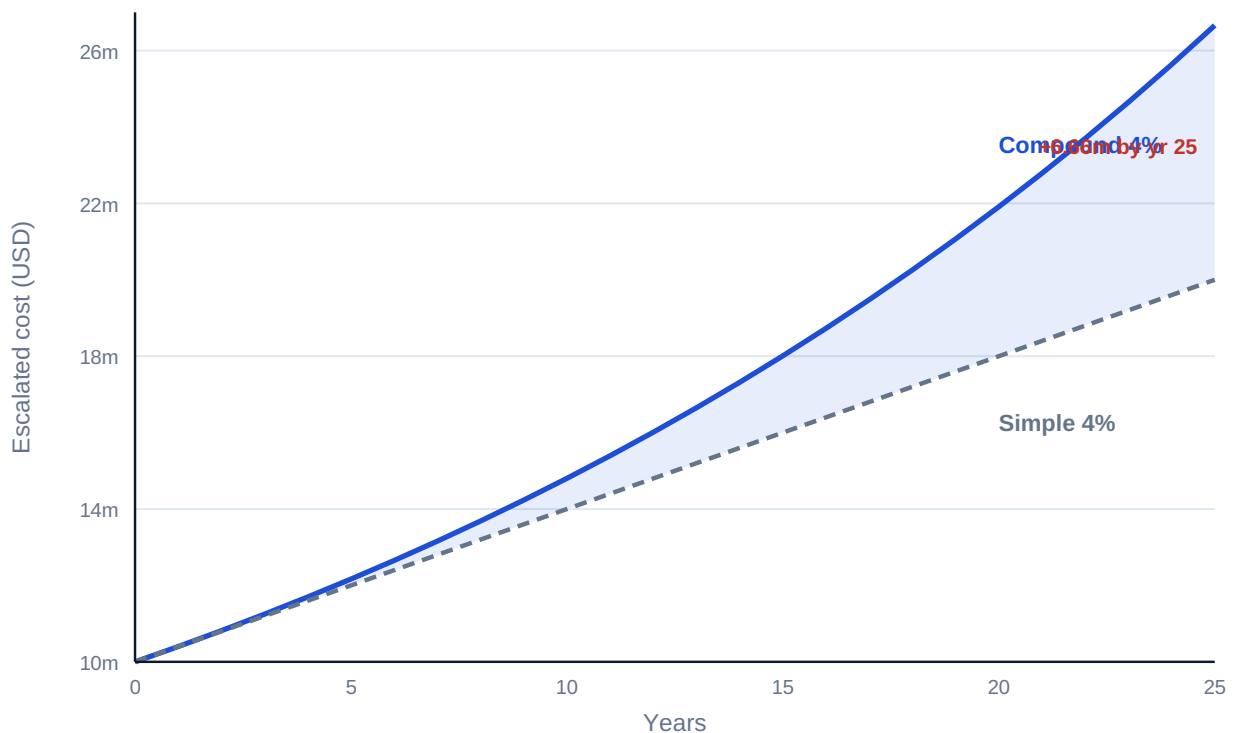


Fig 3.3.2 — Compound versus simple escalation of a USD 10,000,000 cost at 4 %

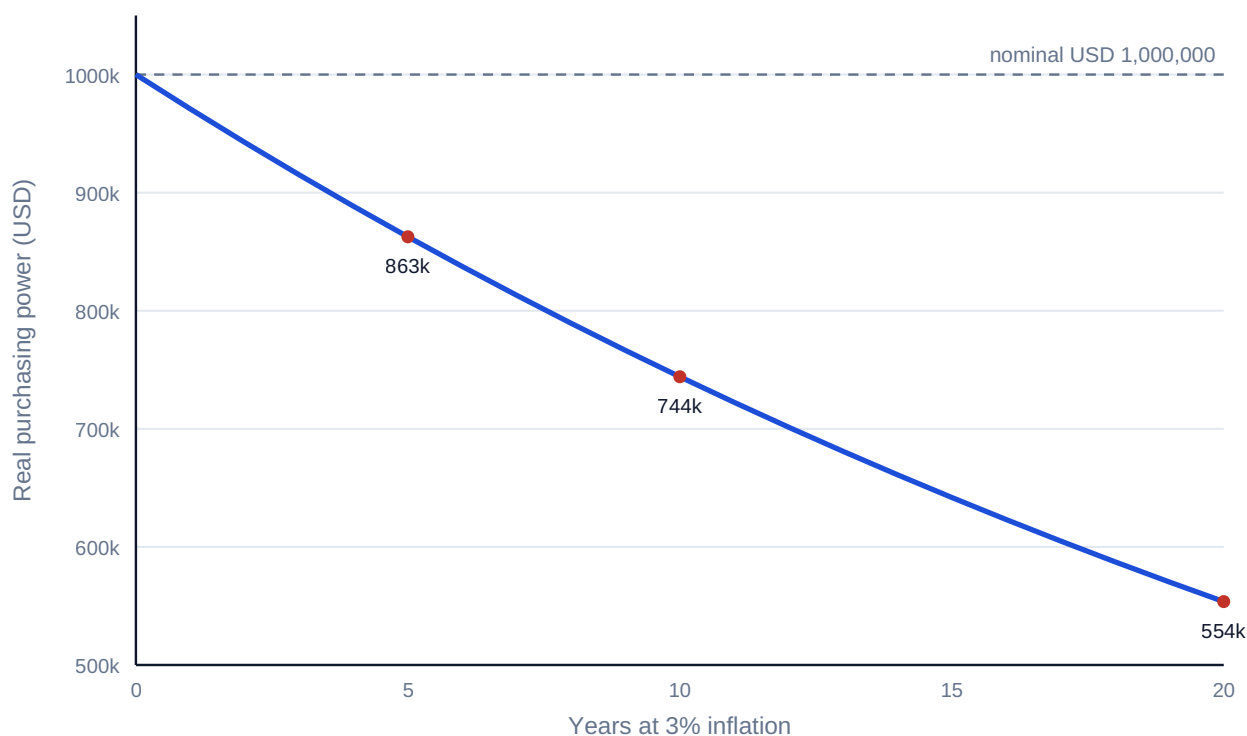


Fig 3.3.1 — What 3 % inflation does to USD 1,000,000 of purchasing power

3.3.3 Currency effects

The problem. Project cash flows often arrive in one currency while debt service, equipment or returns are owed in another. Two rates matter: the **spot rate** now, and the **forward rate** at which future exchange can be contracted. Forwards are priced off interest differentials (covered interest parity, stated here in its textbook form):

$$F \approx S \times (1 + i_{\text{quote}}) / (1 + i_{\text{base}})$$

WORKED EXAMPLE

Worked example 3.3.3 — a one-year SAR/USD forward.

- Setup.** Spot USD 1 = SAR 3.7500 (the indicative peg rate used throughout this book). One-year money costs 5.0 % in USD and 5.5 % in SAR. Estimate the one-year forward.
- Formula.** $F = S \times (1 + i_{\text{SAR}}) / (1 + i_{\text{USD}})$, with $S = 3.7500$.
- Substitution.** $F = 3.7500 \times 1.055 / 1.05$.
- Result.** SAR 3.7679 per USD.
- Interpretation.** The forward is not a forecast; it is arithmetic — the rate at which borrowing in one currency and lending in the other breaks even. A project that leaves a currency mismatch unhedged is not "expecting the spot to hold"; it is running an open position whose size Domain 11 (KA 11.3) teaches you to measure and whose contractual mitigations Domain 12 allocates. **Assumption honesty:** actual pegs, spreads and convertibility restrictions are jurisdiction- and time-specific; every currency figure in this book is illustrative.

3.3.4 Day-count conventions

The problem. "Three months' interest" is not one number. Facility agreements specify a **day-count convention** — how days are counted and over what year they are divided — and the convention moves real money on large balances:

Convention	Rule	Typical home
30/360	Every month 30 days, year 360	Bonds, some term loans
actual/360	Actual days elapsed, year 360	Money markets, most floating-rate loans
actual/365	Actual days elapsed, year 365	Sterling markets, some jurisdictions

WORKED EXAMPLE

Worked example 3.3.4 — one quarter, three conventions.

1. **Setup.** Interest accrues on Kestrel's USD 42,000,000 drawn balance at 6.0 % for one calendar quarter that contains **92 actual days**. Compute the interest under each convention.
2. **Formula.** Interest = balance × rate × (days counted / year basis).
3. **Substitution.** 30/360: $42,000,000 \times 0.06 \times 90/360$. actual/360: $\times 92/360$. actual/365: $\times 92/365$.
4. **Result.** 30/360 **USD 630,000** · actual/365 **USD 635,178** · actual/360 **USD 644,000**.
5. **Interpretation.** The spread between conventions is USD 14,000 on one quarter of one drawdown — and actual/360 is systematically the most expensive because it counts every real day over a short year. Models must implement the convention named in the facility agreement (Domain 12), and the assumption register (3.T.1) records it per instrument; "6 % divided by 4" is not a convention, it is a guess.

AI in this domain — the systematic view

TVM is deterministic, which makes it the safest place in finance to use machine assistance and the most dangerous place to trust it unchecked: a wrong exponent produces a plausible number, not an absurd one. The domain's governed workflow, applied wherever Domains 4–16 discount anything:

1. **AI proposes** — drafts the factor table, schedule or escalated series.
2. **Deterministic checks** — monotone factors; $DF(1)(1+r) = 1$; schedule zeroes; Σ principal = P; one hand-recomputed cell per block.
3. **Assumption register** — rate, basis (nominal/real), compounding frequency, index, and currency of every stream written down (toolkit 3.T.1).
4. **The professional decides and remains accountable** — no AI-produced number reaches a board paper, bid or lender report without a named human owner (Domain 16, KA 16.4).

■ KEY TERMS — KA 3.3

Term	Meaning
Nominal / real rate	Money-terms rate / purchasing-power rate; linked by Fisher.
Fisher relation	$(1+i_{\text{nom}}) = (1+i_{\text{real}})(1+\pi)$.
Inflation π / escalation e	General price drift / specific contractual price growth.
Indexation	Contractual escalation by a published index, with lags, caps, floors.
Spot / forward rate	Exchange rate now / contracted for a future date.
Covered interest parity	Forward $\approx$ spot $\times$ interest-ratio; the no-arbitrage forward.

■ SAMPLE MCQS — KA 3.3

MCQ 3.3-A [3.3.1 · Application] Nominal return 9 %, inflation 3 %. The real return is closest to: - A. 6.00 % - B. 5.83 % - C. 12.27 % - D. 3.00 %

Rationale: $1.09/1.03 - 1 = 5.83$ %. A is the subtraction approximation; C multiplies $1.09 \times 1.03 - 1$ (compounding inflation on instead of off); D confuses the inflation rate itself with the real return.

MCQ 3.3-B [3.3.2 · Application] A USD 10,000,000 cost escalating at 4 % per year is, in year 3: - A. USD 11,200,000 - B. USD 10,400,000 - C. USD 12,486,400 - D. USD 11,248,640

Rationale: $10,000,000 \times 1.04^3 = 11,248,640$. A escalates simply (3×4 %); B stops at one year; C applies four periods' escalation with a decimal slip.

MCQ 3.3-C [3.3.1 · Analysis] A model discounts real (uninflated) cash flows at the sponsor's nominal 9 % hurdle. The result: - A. overstates value, because inflation is counted twice - B. understates value, because inflation is removed from the flows but still charged in the rate - C. is correct if inflation is below 5 % - D. is correct because discount rates are always nominal

Rationale: Real flows with a nominal rate deduct inflation twice — once from the flows, once inside the rate — so value is systematically understated. The consistency rule admits no threshold (C) and no default (D); A reverses the direction of the error.

MCQ 3.3-F [3.3.1 · Application] A model shows a nominal cash flow of USD 2,000,000 in year 5; inflation is 3 %. Its value in today's purchasing power (real terms) is: - A. USD 2,000,000 — real and nominal are equal at year 5 - B. USD 1,725,218 - C. USD 1,700,000 - D. USD 2,318,548

Rationale: $2,000,000 / 1.03^5 = 1,725,218$ — deflating by the price level, not discounting for time value (that happens separately, at a real rate). A ignores five years of inflation; C deflates simply ($2,000,000 \times (1 - 0.03 \times 5) = 1,700,000$); D multiplies by 1.03^5 — inflating instead of deflating.

MCQ 3.3-D [3.3.4 · Application] A USD 42,000,000 balance accrues at 6 % over a 92-day quarter. Under **actual/360** the interest is: - A. USD 630,000 - B. USD 635,178 - C. USD 644,000 - D. USD 620,548

Rationale: $42,000,000 \times 0.06 \times 92/360 = 644,000$. A is 30/360 (90/360); B is actual/365; D uses 90/365 — mixing the two conventions' halves.

MCQ 3.3-E [3.3.2 · Analysis] A 25-year operating model escalates O&M at "4 % simple" to be "conservative". The effect is: - A. conservative — simple escalation always overstates cost - B. anti-conservative — compound escalation exceeds simple by an amount that grows every year, so late-life costs are materially understated - C. neutral — the choice only redistributes cost between years - D. correct — operating contracts always escalate simply

Rationale: Escalation compounds (contracts index on last year's indexed price): by year 25 the compound multiple $1.04^{25} \approx 2.67$ far exceeds the simple 2.00. A claims the reverse; C ignores the widening gap; D asserts a contractual universal that KA 3.3.2's indexation discipline contradicts.

■ SELF-CHECK — KA 3.3

1. State the consistency rule. — Nominal flows with nominal rates, real flows with real rates; never mixed in one calculation.
2. Why does a 25-year concession make the Fisher shortcut dangerous? — The 17 bp error (at 9 %/3 %) compounds across every one of 25 discount factors.
3. Is a forward rate a forecast? — No: it is the no-arbitrage consequence of today's spot and the two interest rates.

— Advanced topics — Domain 3

3.A.1 Continuous compounding

As compounding frequency $m \rightarrow \infty$, $(1 + r/m)^{mn} \rightarrow e^{rn}$. USD 100,000 at 8 % for 3 years compounds continuously to $100,000 \times e^{0.24} = \text{USD } 127,125$ — against 125,971 annually. In project work continuous compounding appears mainly in derivative pricing and some academic appraisal literature; its practical value here is as a bound: no compounding frequency can push growth beyond e^{rn} .

3.A.2 Irregular timing and period conventions

Real cash flows do not arrive on anniversary dates. Three conventions bridge the gap: **exact-date discounting** (each flow discounted by its actual day count — the XNPV approach, standard in transaction models); the **mid-period convention** (flows treated as arriving mid-period, appropriate for continuous operations revenue); and **period-end** (conservative for receipts, default in lender base cases). The convention is an assumption — it belongs in the assumption register, it changes results by up to half a period's discounting, and model audits (Domain 13, KA 13.2) check that one convention is applied everywhere.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Worked example 3.A.2 — the payment on day 500.

1. **Setup.** A USD 1,000,000 completion payment falls on **day 500** from the valuation date; the discount rate is 9.0 % annual. Compare exact-date discounting with the period-end habit of "call it year 2".
2. **Formula.** Exact-date: $PV = x / (1 + r)^{(\text{days}/365)}$.
3. **Substitution.** $1,000,000 / 1.09^{(500/365)} = 1,000,000 / 1.09^{1.36986}$.
4. **Result.** **USD 888,650.** "Year 2" rounding gives 841,680 — **USD 46,970 low**; "year 1" gives 917,431 — USD 28,781 high.
5. **Interpretation.** Bucketing a mid-period flow to the nearer anniversary mis-states value by up to half a period's discounting — nearly 5 % here. Transaction models discount on dates; period models declare mid-period or period-end explicitly and apply it everywhere. The convention chosen matters less than its disclosure and consistency.

3.A.3 Term structures — when one rate is not enough

A single flat r assumes money has the same price at every horizon. Markets disagree: rates form a **term structure**, and precise valuation discounts each period's flow at that period's rate (equivalently, its own $DF(t)$ from a curve). Project models typically justify a flat rate as a deliberate simplification of a curve — acceptable when documented and stress-tested (Domain 6, KA 6.4), a silent error when inherited unexamined from a template.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Worked example 3.A.3 — flat rate versus the curve.

1. **Setup.** A contractor is owed USD 1,000,000 at the end of each of years 1 and 2. The spot curve prices 1-year money at 5.0 % and 2-year money at 7.0 %; the model uses a flat 6.0 %. How far wrong is the flat rate?
2. **Formula.** Curve: $PV = x/(1 + r_1) + x/(1 + r_2)^2$. Flat: $PV = x/(1+r) + x/(1+r)^2$.
3. **Substitution.** Curve: $1,000,000/1.05 + 1,000,000/1.07^2 = 952,381 + 873,439$. Flat: $943,396 + 889,996$.
4. **Result.** Curve **USD 1,825,820**; flat **USD 1,833,393** — the flat model overstates value by **USD 7,573** (0.4 %).
5. **Interpretation.** The flat 6 % "averages" the curve but misprices both flows — too harsh on the near one, too kind on the far one — and the errors do not cancel unless the stream is symmetric around the average tenor. For a two-flow example the drift is small; on a 25-year concession against a steep curve it moves tens of millions. The audit question is never "is the rate reasonable?" but "which curve does this rate summarise, and has the summary been stress-tested?"

3.A.4 The reviewer's TVM eye

Experienced reviewers do not recompute everything; they run invariants. The domain's collected set: factors decline; $DF(1)(1+r) = 1$; annuity factor $\times r \rightarrow 1 - DF(n)$; schedules zero out; Σ principal = P ; effective $\geq$ nominal, with equality only at annual compounding; real $<$ nominal whenever $\pi > 0$; forward off-spot in the direction of the interest differential. Any violated invariant is a defect somewhere — find it before anyone downstream builds on it.

— Industry variations — Domain 3

The machinery is universal; its parameters are sectoral, and a project finance leader reads the sector before trusting any inherited rate, tenor or convention:

- **Power and renewables.** Long contracted tenors (20–35 years) make value acutely curve-sensitive (3.A.3) and escalation-sensitive (3.3.2); availability and capacity payments are near-annuities, so the annuity family does most of the valuation work. Debt sculpting to seasonal cash flows (Domain 10) starts from monthly, not annual, discounting.
- **Transport concessions.** Patronage risk pushes discount rates up and makes single-rate valuation least defensible — scenario-based rates and revenue stress tests (Domain 7, KA 7.4) ride directly on this domain's factors.

- **Water and regulated utilities.** Regulatory reset cycles (often 5-yearly) partition the horizon: within-period flows discount at financing rates; across resets, the real/nominal discipline (3.3.1) dominates because regulators commonly work in real terms while lenders live in nominal.
- **Digital infrastructure.** Shorter economic lives and refresh capex compress tenors: bullet and mini-perm shapes (3.2.2) with deliberate refinancing (Domain 15) are standard, so the balloon-risk arithmetic of Case B is daily practice, not a cautionary tale.
- **Oil, gas and mining.** Commodity-linked revenue makes escalation assumptions (3.3.2) the loudest value driver, and multi-currency operations make the day-count and FX conventions (3.3.3–3.3.4) contractual battlegrounds rather than back-office detail.
- **Social infrastructure PPPs.** Availability payments in advance are common — the annuity-due reading (WE 3.2.1b) is the difference between winning and mispricing a bid.

— Case study — Domain 3: choosing between an upfront grant and an availability stream (water / PPP)

Situation. Kestrel Water SPC's grantor offers two support packages for the desalination concession, and the board must choose one at financial close:

- **Package U:** a single upfront capital grant of **USD 58,000,000** at completion.
- **Package S:** an availability supplement of **USD 5,600,000 per year for 25 years**, paid annually in arrears from completion.

Kestrel evaluates support at its 8.0 % project discount rate. The grantor's advisers privately evaluate at 10 %.

Analysis. The stream's value to Kestrel: $AF(0.08, 25) = (1 - 1.08^{-25})/0.08 = 10.674776$; $PV = 5,600,000 \times 10.674776 = \text{USD } 59,778,747$ — worth **USD 1,778,747 more** than the upfront grant. To the grantor's advisers at 10 %: $AF(0.10, 25) = 9.077040$; $PV = 5,600,000 \times 9.077040 = \text{USD } 50,831,424$ — worth **USD 7,168,576 less** than the grant they would otherwise pay today.

The decision. Both sides prefer a different package from the same facts — a discount-rate wedge, not a disagreement about arithmetic. Kestrel takes the stream (worth more at 8 %); the grantor is glad to give it (cheaper at 10 %); the deal closes with both counterparties better off by their own measure. The board minute records the rate, the convention (annual, in arrears) and the sensitivity: the stream's advantage to Kestrel disappears if its discount rate rises past ≈ 8.36 % — the **breakeven rate** at which $AF \times 5,600,000 = 58,000,000$, i.e. $AF = 10.3571$.

What the domain teaches here. Valuation is always at a rate, for a party; streams and lumps are only comparable through $PV(x)$; and the negotiation surface between two parties' rates is where structuring value lives (Domain 7 revisits this as tariff design; Domain 9 as the grant-versus-support decision).

— Case study B — Domain 3: the bullet that had to be refinanced (energy / refinancing)

Situation. A 30 MW peaking-plant SPV borrowed **USD 30,000,000** for 7 years. The sponsor chose a **bullet** (interest-only at 7.5 %, principal at maturity) over the lenders' preferred **annuity** shape, to keep early cash for distributions.

The two prices. Annuity instalment: $A = 30,000,000 \times 0.075 / (1 - 1.075^{-7}) = \text{USD } 5,664,009$ per year; total paid 39,648,066, of which interest **USD 9,648,066**. Bullet: interest $30,000,000 \times 0.075 = 2,250,000$ per year — total interest **USD 15,750,000**, plus the full USD 30,000,000 due in year 7. The bullet pays **USD 6,101,934 more interest** for the privilege of deferral — and retains the entire principal as **refinancing risk**.

What happened. At year 7 the credit market had repriced: the refinancing cleared at 9.8 %, and the new 7-year annuity instalment on the rolled principal became $30,000,000 \times 0.098 / (1 - 1.098^{-7}) = 6,121,646$ — against 5,664,009 had the original annuity simply been running to zero. Distributions locked up under the new facility's covenants for two years (Domain 10, KA 10.4).

What the domain teaches here. A schedule shape is a risk allocation, not a formatting choice: the annuity retires rate risk continuously; the bullet stores it at maturity, priced at a rate nobody today knows. Deferral has a computable minimum cost (the interest differential) and an uncomputable tail (the refinancing market) — leadership means pricing the first honestly and sizing the second deliberately (Domain 15, KA 15.3).

— Executive perspective — Domain 3

What a project finance director cannot delegate in this domain:

- **The rate.** Analysts compute with a discount rate; directors own it. Whoever sets r sets the answer — the choice is a governance act (Domain 4 gives it method; Domain 3 makes its power visible).
- **The world.** Nominal or real, once, for the whole model — and the director asks which, out loud, at the first model review.
- **The conventions.** In-arrears vs in-advance, compounding frequency, day counts, escalation indices: each is small, each moves millions at scale, and together they are why the assumption register (3.T.1) is a board-visible artefact, not analyst hygiene.
- **The verification culture.** The invariants of 3.A.4 cost minutes; unverified TVM in a signed bid costs careers. The director's question is never "who computed this?" but "who recomputed this?" — and, where AI drafted it, the answer must name a human.

— Calculation exercises — Domain 3

Exercise 3.1 A land payment of USD 850,000 falls due in 8 years; the applicable discount rate is 11 %. Value it today. Solution. $PV = 850,000 / 1.11^8 = 850,000 / 2.304538 = \text{USD } 368,838$ (368,837.52). Common error: using $n = 7$ gives 409,410 — an off-by-one from counting "in 8 years" as 7 compounding periods.

Exercise 3.2 A USD 2,500,000 equipment loan is repaid monthly over 20 years at a 5.0 % nominal annual rate compounded monthly. Find the monthly payment. Solution. Periodic rate $0.05/12 = 0.004167$; $n = 240$; $A = 2,500,000 \times 0.004167 / (1 - 1.004167^{-240}) = \text{USD } 16,499$ per month (16,498.89). Common error: using the EAR (5.116 %) with 20 annual periods misstates debt service materially.

Exercise 3.3 Convert a 12 % nominal rate compounded monthly to its effective annual rate.

Solution. $(1 + 0.01)^{12} - 1 = 1.126825 - 1 = \mathbf{12.68\%}$. Common error: reporting 12 % — the nominal — as "the rate" in a comparison against an annually-compounded 12.5 % offer, which is in fact cheaper.

Exercise 3.4 A transmission wayleave pays USD 1,200,000 per year indefinitely; the discount rate is 8.5 %. Value the perpetuity. Solution. $PV = 1,200,000 / 0.085 = \mathbf{USD\ 14,117,647}$. Common error: applying a long annuity factor (say 30 years, $AF = 10.694$) "as approximately forever" understates value by $\approx 9\%$.

Exercise 3.5 A market forecast promises a 12 % nominal return with 5 % inflation. State the real return, exactly and by the shortcut, and the shortcut's error. Solution. Exact: $1.12/1.05 - 1 = \mathbf{6.67\%}$ (6.6667 %). Shortcut: $12 - 5 = \mathbf{7.00\%}$. The shortcut overstates the real return by **33 basis points** — material over any long horizon.

— Practitioner's toolkit — Domain 3

Adoption-ready artefacts; adapt headings to your organisation, then keep them stable.

Toolkit 3.T.1 — TVM assumption register (one row per modelled stream)

Field	Discipline it enforces
Stream name & source document	Every number traces to a contract or estimate
Currency	Mismatches surface (KA 3.3.3)
Nominal or real	The consistency rule (3.3.1), stated not assumed
Rate & its owner	The director owns r (Executive perspective)
Compounding frequency & day count	Effective-rate honesty (3.2.3)
Timing convention (arrears/advance/mid-period)	Half-period errors caught (3.A.2)
Escalation index, lag, cap/floor	Contractual, not invented (3.3.2)

Toolkit 3.T.2 — Schedule QA checklist

- [] Payment recomputed independently of the model (different implementer or method).
- [] Final balance exactly zero; Σ principal = original loan.
- [] Periodic rate = nominal / frequency; period count = years $\times$ frequency.
- [] Discount factors monotone; $DF(1) \times (1 + r) = 1$.
- [] Display rounding only — full precision beneath every printed figure.
- [] AI-drafted content marked, and its human verifier named (Domain 16, KA 16.4).

Toolkit 3.T.3 — Escalation register

For each escalating line: base amount and base date · index (publisher, series, definition) · lag · formula (full/partial indexation, weightings) · cap/floor · compounding basis · the clause reference in

the contract. A model whose escalation register is complete can survive a Domain 13 model audit; one whose escalation is "4 % because last year" cannot.

— Exam preparation — Domain 3

The calculation traps. Off-by-one periods ("in year 5" vs "after 5 years") · simple-for- compound substitution · rounded discount factors in the arithmetic · annuity-due priced as ordinary · EAR used as the periodic rate · nominal/real mixing · escalation applied simply · tenor mismatch in annuity factors (the 3.2-A distractor D) · treating a forward as a forecast.

Reflection questions. 1. Your CFO asks for "the value of the concession". What three questions must you answer before any number is defensible? (At what rate; in which world — nominal or real; under which timing conventions.) 2. A lender and a sponsor disagree about the value of the same payment stream. Under what conditions are both right — and where does that create negotiating room? (Case study A.) 3. Which invariant checks would have caught the last TVM error you saw in the wild — and why didn't they run? (3.A.4; toolkit 3.T.2.)

— Domain 3 summary

Money's value is a function of time, and this domain built the complete conversion machinery: compounding and discounting ($FV(x)$, $PV(x)$, $DF(t)$); the annuity family that prices every level stream from availability payments to debt service ($AF(r, n)$), perpetuities, the three loan shapes and their risk meanings); frequency and effective-rate honesty; and the three real-world adjustments — Fisher-consistent inflation treatment, contract-grade escalation, and no-arbitrage currency forwards. Its discipline is as important as its formulae: one world per model, full precision beneath displayed rounding, conventions in the assumption register, invariants run on every schedule, and machine-drafted arithmetic verified by a named human before anyone relies on it. Every discounted number in the thirteen domains that follow stands on this one.

04

DOMAIN 4

Investment Appraisal and Capital Budgeting (quantitative)

Group: Foundations (Domain 4 of 4 in Part One). **Target:** ~70 pages. **Binds to:** the PCI Book Pattern Specification and the shared registries ([docs/books/registries/](#)). This domain is the home of the appraisal symbols — NPV, IRR, MIRR, PI, EAV — and builds directly on Domain 3's machinery ($PV(x)$, $DF(t)$, $AF(r, n)$): every formula here is a disciplined arrangement of those parts. British English; USD (+SAR where useful, indicative USD 1 $\approx$ SAR 3.75).

— Why this domain exists

Domain 3 taught how to move money across time; this domain teaches how to decide with it. Investment appraisal is where analysis meets commitment: the techniques here — net present value, internal rates of return, payback, profitability, equivalent annual value — are how a project finance leader turns forecast cash flows into a defensible yes, no, or not-this-one. The measures are deliberately plural because each answers a different question: NPV measures value created; IRR measures the return embedded in the flows; payback measures exposure; the profitability index measures value per scarce dollar; equivalent annual value compares unlike lifetimes. Leadership in this domain means knowing which question the decision actually asks — and refusing to let a single seductive percentage (usually IRR) answer all of them. Domain 6 industrialises these calculations in the financial model; Domain 10 replays them from the lender's side of the table.

Learning objectives. After this domain a candidate can: compute and interpret NPV and explain why it is the primary measure of value; compute IRR, recognise its pathologies (multiple roots, scale-blindness, reinvestment assumption) and know when it misleads; compute MIRR and state what it fixes and what it does not; apply payback and discounted payback as exposure measures, not value measures; rank with the profitability index under capital rationing; compare unequal lives with equivalent annual value; resolve NPV-IRR conflicts on mutually exclusive projects; and subject any machine-produced appraisal to the family's verification rule.

The master appraisal. The Kestrel Water SPC financing of Domain 3 now faces its investment decision. Building the plant requires $I_0 = \text{USD } 60,000,000$ today; the operating model forecasts **net cash inflows of USD 8,900,000 per year for 15 years**; the board's discount rate remains **8.0 %**. Every KA below interrogates this one decision from a different angle.

KNOWLEDGE AREA 4.1

The discounted measures: NPV, IRR and MIRR

Topics: 4.1.1 net present value · 4.1.2 IRR and its pathologies · 4.1.3 MIRR.

4.1.1 Net present value

Definition. NPV discounts every cash flow to today and nets off the investment:

$$\text{NPV} = \sum \text{CF}_t / (1 + r)^t - I_0$$

A positive NPV means the project returns more than the capital's required return r — it creates value; a negative NPV destroys it. NPV's authority rests on three properties no rival measure shares: it is **additive** (portfolio NPV is the sum of project NPVs), it is **scale-aware** (twice the project, twice the NPV), and it embeds the **correct reinvestment assumption** (cash thrown off is assumed to earn r , the opportunity cost — not the project's own return).

WORKED EXAMPLE

Worked example 4.1.1 — should Kestrel build?

1. **Setup.** $I_0 = \text{USD } 60,000,000$; net inflows $\text{USD } 8,900,000$ per year for 15 years (in arrears); $r = 8.0\%$.
2. **Formula.** For a level stream, $\text{NPV} = A \times \text{AF}(r, n) - I_0$ (Domain 3, KA 3.2).
3. **Substitution.** $\text{AF}(0.08, 15) = 8.559479$; $\text{NPV} = 8,900,000 \times 8.559479 - 60,000,000 = 76,179,360 - 60,000,000$.
4. **Result.** $\text{NPV} = +\text{USD } 16,179,360$ ($\approx \text{SAR } 60.7$ million indicatively).
5. **Interpretation.** At the board's 8 % the plant is worth $\text{USD } 16.2$ million more than it costs — build, on these forecasts. The phrase carrying the professional weight is on these forecasts: NPV is only as honest as the cash flows and the rate beneath it, which is why Domain 6's model discipline and this domain's sensitivity habits (KA 4.3.3) are part of the appraisal, not decoration around it.

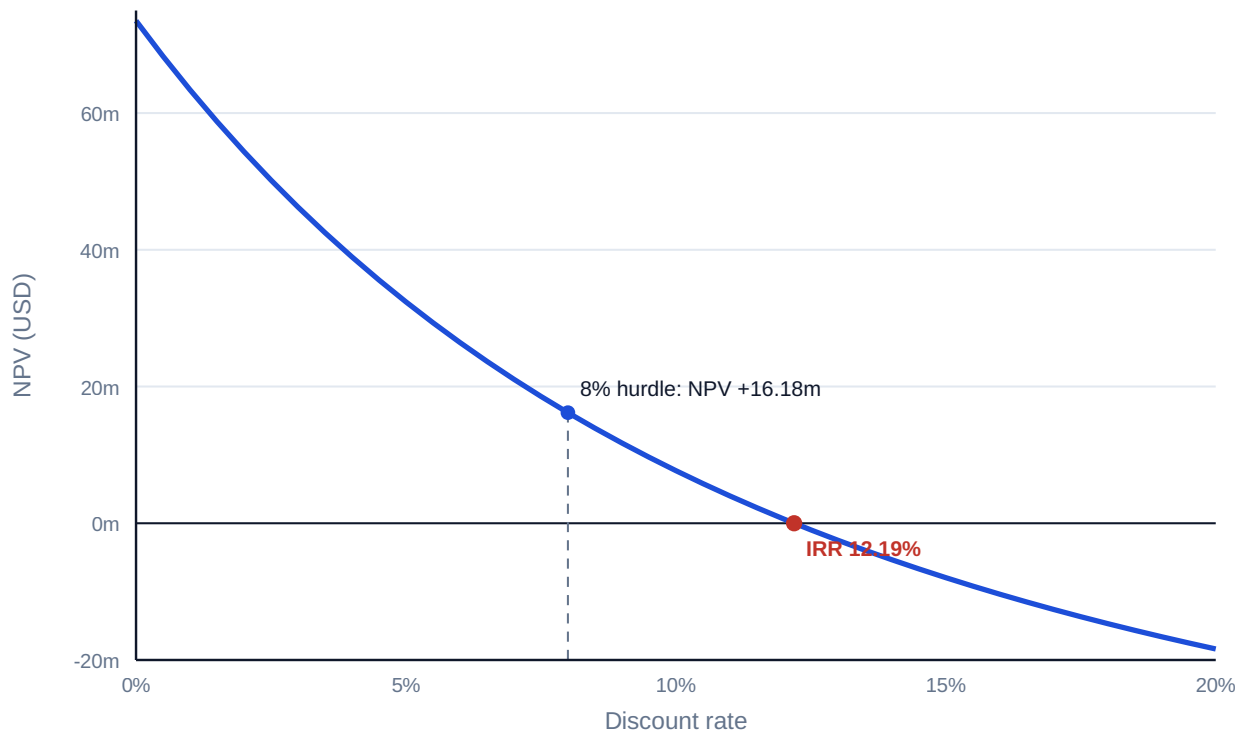


Fig 4.1.1 — Kestrel's NPV profile

4.1.2 IRR and its pathologies

Definition. The internal rate of return is the discount rate at which NPV is zero — the break-even price of capital:

$$\text{NPV}(\text{IRR}) = 0$$

For Kestrel: solve $8,900,000 \times \text{AF}(r, 15) = 60,000,000 \rightarrow \text{AF} = 6.741573 \rightarrow \text{IRR} = 12.19\%$. Read against an 8 % hurdle, the project clears with 4.19 points to spare — the same verdict as NPV, expressed as a margin of safety rather than a value.

Why decision-makers love it — and where it lies. A percentage needs no context, which is precisely its danger. The three standing pathologies:

1. **Multiple roots.** IRR is a polynomial root; flows that change sign more than once can have more than one. The classic mining/decommissioning shape — invest, harvest, pay to restore — $(-1,000,000, +2,300,000, -1,320,000)$ — satisfies $\text{NPV} = 0$ at **both 10 % and 20 %**; between them NPV is positive (about +1,890 at 15 %), outside, negative. Quoting "the IRR" of such a project is meaningless; NPV at the actual cost of capital remains well defined.
2. **Scale-blindness.** A 40 % IRR on USD 100,000 creates less value than 15 % on USD 20,000,000. IRR ranks intensity, NPV ranks money; mutually exclusive choices need money (KA 4.3.1).
3. **The reinvestment fiction.** IRR mathematically assumes interim cash is reinvested at the IRR itself — flattering for high-IRR projects, since no treasury desk reinvests at 28 %. MIRR (4.1.3) exists to repair exactly this.

Common pitfall — comparing IRRs across different tenors. A 3-year 18 % and a 15-year 13 % are not ordered: the short project leaves twelve years of reinvestment risk the percentage hides. The honest comparison is NPV over a common horizon, or EAV (KA 4.2.3).

4.1.3 MIRR — the modified internal rate of return

Definition. MIRR discounts outflows at the finance rate and compounds inflows to the terminal date at an explicit reinvestment rate, then reads the single rate connecting the two:

$$\text{MIRR} = (\text{FV}(\text{inflows at } r_{\text{reinvest}}) / \text{PV}(\text{outflows at } r_{\text{finance}}))^{(1/n)} - 1$$

WORKED EXAMPLE

Worked example 4.1.3 — Kestrel's honest percentage.

1. **Setup.** The master appraisal, with both finance and reinvestment rates set to the 8 % opportunity cost.
2. **Formula.** Terminal value of the inflows $\text{TV} = A \times \text{FVAF}(r, n)$ where $\text{FVAF}(0.08, 15) = (1.08^{15} - 1)/0.08 = 27.152114$; then $\text{MIRR} = (\text{TV}/I_0)^{(1/15)} - 1$.
3. **Substitution.** $\text{TV} = 8,900,000 \times 27.152114 = 241,653,814$; $\text{MIRR} = (241,653,814 / 60,000,000)^{(1/15)} - 1 = 4.027564^{(1/15)} - 1$.
4. **Result.** **MIRR = 9.73 %** — against an IRR of 12.19 %.
5. **Interpretation.** Two and a half points of Kestrel's IRR were the reinvestment fiction. MIRR is single-valued even for sign-changing flows and states its reinvestment assumption in the open — which is why credit committees increasingly ask for it alongside IRR. It remains a rate: still scale-blind, still not additive. The order of authority stands: **NPV decides; rates explain.**

AI in this KA

Appraisal is where optimisation pressure meets a suggestible tool: an assistant asked to "get the IRR above 12 %" will find assumptions that do. The governed workflow inverts the prompt — AI is asked to attack the appraisal (which assumptions move NPV most? where does the IRR become multiple?), the analyst reruns the golden checks (NPV at the stated rate recomputed independently; IRR verified by substitution back into the NPV equation; MIRR's terminal value re-derived), and the professional owns the recommendation. **AI proposes; the professional verifies, decides and remains accountable.**

■ KEY TERMS — KA 4.1

Term	Meaning
NPV	Σ discounted cash flows – investment; the primary value measure.
IRR	The rate at which $\text{NPV} = 0$; the flows' embedded return.
NPV profile	NPV plotted against the discount rate; IRR is its zero-crossing.
Multiple roots	Two or more IRRs when flow signs change more than once.
Reinvestment assumption	NPV assumes interim cash earns r ; IRR assumes it earns the IRR.
MIRR	Single rate from explicit finance and reinvestment rates.

■ SAMPLE MCQS — KA 4.1

MCQ 4.1-A [4.1.1 · Application] A project costs USD 60,000,000 and returns USD 8,900,000 per year for 15 years; the discount rate is 8 % (AF = 8.559479). Its NPV is: - A. +USD 16,179,360 - B. +USD 73,500,000 - C. -USD 16,179,360 - D. +USD 76,179,360

Rationale: $8,900,000 \times 8.559479 - 60,000,000 = +16,179,360$. B is the undiscounted surplus ($8.9 \times 15 - 60$); C reverses the sign (investment minus value); D forgets to deduct the investment at all.

MCQ 4.1-B [4.1.2 · Analysis] A project's cash flows are -1,000,000, +2,300,000, -1,320,000. Which statement is correct? - A. its IRR is 10 % - B. its IRR is 20 % - C. it has two IRRs (10 % and 20 %), so decision by IRR is indeterminate and NPV at the cost of capital must decide - D. it has no IRR, so it must be rejected

Rationale: Two sign changes admit two roots — both 10 % and 20 % zero the NPV, which is positive between them. A and B are each half the truth and therefore wrong as "the" IRR; D confuses indeterminate ranking with non-viability — at a 15 % cost of capital the NPV is (slightly) positive.

MCQ 4.1-C [4.1.3 · Application] Using an 8 % finance and reinvestment rate, the master appraisal's terminal value of inflows is USD 241,653,814 on an investment of USD 60,000,000 over 15 years. MIRR is closest to: - A. 12.19 % - B. 9.73 % - C. 8.00 % - D. 26.85 %

Rationale: $(241,653,814/60,000,000)^{(1/15)} - 1 = 9.73 \%$. A is the unmodified IRR; C is the reinvestment rate itself; D divides the 4.03× money multiple by 15 as if returns were simple.

MCQ 4.1-D [4.1.1 · Analysis] Which property justifies NPV's primacy over IRR for accept/reject and ranking decisions? - A. NPV is easier to compute - B. NPV is expressed as a percentage - C. NPV is additive and scale-aware, and assumes reinvestment at the opportunity cost - D. NPV never requires a forecast

Rationale: The three structural properties of 4.1.1. A is irrelevant and untrue at scale; B describes IRR, not NPV; D is false — NPV consumes the same forecasts as every measure.

■ SELF-CHECK — KA 4.1

1. State the master appraisal's three verdicts and their meanings. — NPV +16.18m (value created at 8 %); IRR 12.19 % (break-even rate, 4.19-point margin); MIRR 9.73 % (return with honest 8 % reinvestment).
2. Why does a mining-with-restoration cash flow break IRR? — Two sign changes → up to two roots; "the" IRR does not exist.
3. What single question decides between NPV and IRR when they disagree? — Which project adds more money at the actual cost of capital — NPV's answer, by construction.

KNOWLEDGE AREA 4.2

The complementary measures

Topics: 4.2.1 payback and discounted payback · 4.2.2 profitability index · 4.2.3 equivalent annual value.

4.2.1 Payback and discounted payback

Definitions. **Payback** is the time until cumulative cash inflows repay the investment; **discounted payback** repeats the question in present-value terms. Neither measures value — both measure **exposure**: how long the capital is at risk before it has come home.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Worked example 4.2.1 — how long is Kestrel's money in the ground?

1. **Setup.** The master appraisal: $I_0 = 60,000,000$; inflows 8,900,000 per year; $r = 8\%$.
2. **Formula.** Payback = I_0 / A for a level stream. Discounted payback: the smallest n with $A \times AF(r, n) \geq I_0$, interpolated within the crossing year.
3. **Substitution.** Simple: $60,000,000 / 8,900,000 = 6.74$. Discounted: after year 10 the cumulative PV is $8,900,000 \times 6.710081 = 59,719,724$ — USD 280,276 short; year 11's discounted flow is $8,900,000 \times 0.428883 = 3,817,057$; fraction $280,276 / 3,817,057 = 0.07$.
4. **Result.** Payback **6.74 years**; discounted payback **10.07 years**.
5. **Interpretation.** The gap between the two numbers — three and a third years — is the price of time value: nominal repayment by year 7 does not return the capital's worth until year 10. For a 15-year concession, ten years of exposure is a risk fact the board should see beside the +16.2m NPV, not instead of it. The standing rule: **payback screens; NPV decides**. Payback's known biases — it ignores everything after the cut-off and penalises long-life infrastructure precisely for being long-lived — make it a veto-check, never a ranking.

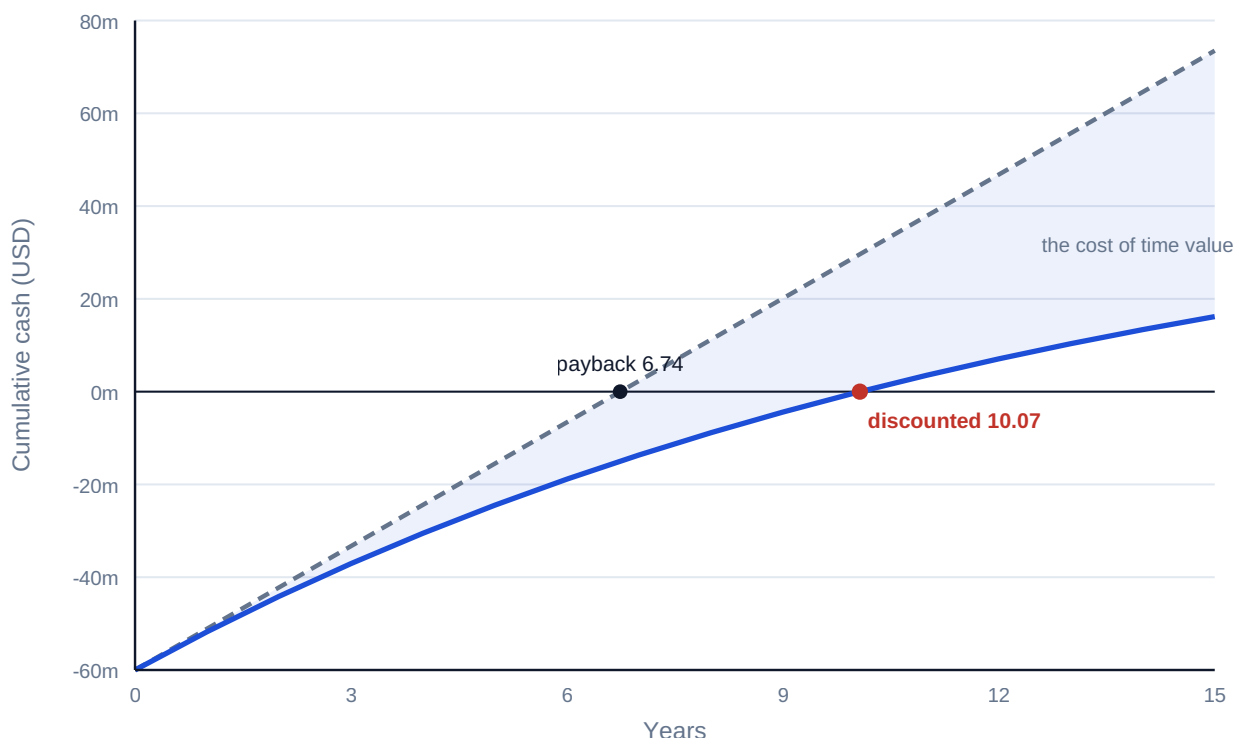


Fig 4.2.1 — Two paybacks: cumulative cash versus cumulative present value

4.2.2 The profitability index

Definition. Value created per unit of scarce capital:

$$PI = PV(\text{future cash flows}) / I_0$$

Kestrel: $76,179,360 / 60,000,000 = **1.270**$ — each invested dollar buys USD 1.27 of present value. PI ranks efficiency and earns its keep in exactly one situation: **capital rationing** (KA 4.3.2), where the question is not "is this project good?" but "which portfolio of good projects fits the budget?". Unconstrained, PI adds nothing to NPV and can mis-rank mutually exclusive projects of different scale — the same scale-blindness as IRR, in ratio form.

4.2.3 Equivalent annual value

Definition. EAV converts an NPV over a life of n years into the level annual amount with the same present value:

$$EAV = NPV / AF(r, n)$$

Its natural habitat is **unequal lives**: comparing a 3-year asset with a 5-year asset by raw NPV smuggles in the assumption that the world ends when the shorter one does.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Worked example 4.2.3 — two pumps, unequal lives.

1. **Setup.** Kestrel must choose a dosing-pump system. **System A:** costs 5,000,000, runs 3 years, operating cost 800,000 per year. **System B:** costs 7,600,000, runs 5 years, operating cost 500,000 per year. Same duty; $r = 8\%$. (Costs, so lower is better.)
2. **Formula.** $PV \text{ of cost} = \text{capex} + \text{opex} \times AF(r, n)$; equivalent annual cost $EAC = PV / AF(r, n)$.
3. **Substitution.** A: $5,000,000 + 800,000 \times 2.577097 = 7,061,678$; $EAC = 7,061,678 / 2.577097$. B: $7,600,000 + 500,000 \times 3.992710 = 9,596,355$; $EAC = 9,596,355 / 3.992710$.
4. **Result.** A: **USD 2,740,168 per year.** B: **USD 2,403,469 per year** — B is cheaper by USD 336,699 every year, despite the 52 % higher purchase price.
5. **Interpretation.** Raw PV comparison (7.06m vs 9.60m) points the wrong way because it prices three years against five. EAV puts both on a per-year footing under the standard assumption that each system is replaced in kind at the end of its life. When that assumption fails — technology shifts, the duty ends — model the actual replacement chain instead (Domain 8's lifecycle costing).

AI in this KA

Screening portfolios is high-volume, formulaic work — the natural first place an organisation automates appraisal, and the first place systematic error industrialises. Two governed habits: the screening tool's formulae are validated once against this domain's golden examples (the registry pattern, [_build/verify_formulas.py](#)), and every auto-screened rejection above a materiality line gets a human review — a portfolio can lose its best project to one wrong sign convention, silently, forever.

■ KEY TERMS — KA 4.2

Term	Meaning
Payback / discounted payback	Years for cumulative (discounted) inflows to repay I_0 ; exposure measures.
PI	PV of inflows / I_0 ; value per scarce dollar, for rationing.
EAV / EAC	NPV (cost PV) converted to a level annual equivalent via $AF(r, n)$.
Unequal lives	The comparison EAV exists to make honest.
Replacement chain	The explicit alternative when like-for-like replacement fails.

■ SAMPLE MCQS — KA 4.2

MCQ 4.2-A [4.2.1 · Application] For the master appraisal (60m in, 8.9m/yr, 8 %), the discounted payback is closest to: - A. 6.74 years - B. 10.07 years - C. 8.00 years - D. 15.00 years

Rationale: Cumulative PV reaches 59.72m after year 10; the 0.28m shortfall is 7 % of year 11's 3.82m discounted flow → 10.07. A is the simple payback; C confuses the discount rate with a duration; D is the whole life.

MCQ 4.2-B [4.2.3 · Application] System A (PV of costs 7,061,678 over 3 years, $AF = 2.577097$) versus System B (PV 9,596,355 over 5 years, $AF = 3.992710$). The correct comparison and choice is: - A. raw PV: A is cheaper, choose A - B. equivalent annual cost: A 2,740,168 vs B 2,403,469 — choose B - C. equivalent annual cost: A 2,353,893 vs B 1,919,271 — choose B - D. purchase price: A is cheaper, choose A

Rationale: Unequal lives require EAC: $7,061,678/2.577097 = 2,740,168$ vs $9,596,355/3.992710 = 2,403,469$. A and D compare unlike horizons; C divides each PV by its raw life in years ($\div 3$ and $\div 5$), annualising without discounting — the right instinct with the wrong arithmetic.

MCQ 4.2-C [4.2.1 · Analysis] A board adopts "payback under 5 years" as its sole investment criterion. The predictable portfolio distortion is: - A. none — payback is conservative, so the portfolio is safe - B. systematic bias against long-lived infrastructure and toward short-cycle projects, regardless of value created - C. excessive investment in high-NPV projects - D. elimination of all risk

Rationale: Payback ignores everything beyond its cut-off, so a 15-year concession with NPV +16m loses to a 4-year project with NPV +1m. That is a value distortion, not conservatism (A); C reverses the effect; D confuses shorter exposure with no risk.

MCQ 4.2-D [4.2.2 · Recall] The profitability index earns its place in appraisal when: - A. projects are mutually exclusive and differ in scale - B. capital is rationed and the question is which portfolio of positive-NPV projects fits the budget - C. cash flows change sign more than once - D. lives are unequal

Rationale: PI ranks value per scarce dollar — the rationing question exactly. A is where PI (like IRR) mis-ranks by scale; C is MIRR's territory; D is EAV's.

■ SELF-CHECK — KA 4.2

1. Why is discounted payback always later than simple payback? — Discounting shrinks every inflow, so the cumulative line climbs more slowly (equal only if $r = 0$).
2. State Kestrel's PI and its meaning. — 1.270: each dollar invested buys 1.27 dollars of present value.

3. What assumption does EAV smuggle in, and when must you drop it? — Like-for-like replacement in perpetuity; drop it when the duty ends or technology shifts, and model the real chain.

KNOWLEDGE AREA 4.3

Decision contexts: exclusivity, rationing and judgment

Topics: 4.3.1 mutually exclusive investments · 4.3.2 capital rationing · 4.3.3 the limits of the numbers.

4.3.1 Mutually exclusive investments

The conflict. Choosing one project instead of another is where NPV and IRR famously disagree. Kestrel's board weighs two intake designs (same risk class, $r = 8\%$):

Design	I_0	Net inflow $\times 5$ yrs	NPV @ 8 %	IRR
P (compact)	5,000,000	2,000,000	+2,985,420	28.65 %
Q (full-scale)	20,000,000	6,000,000	+3,956,260	15.24 %

IRR shouts P; NPV says Q adds USD 970,840 more money. The tie-breaker is the **incremental project** Q–P: invest a further 15,000,000 for a further 4,000,000 per year — an incremental IRR of **10.42 %**, above the 8 % cost of capital. The extra capital earns its keep, so take the bigger project. **Rule: when exclusivity forces a choice, rank by NPV; use incremental IRR only to narrate the same answer.** (At any hurdle above 10.42 % the ranking genuinely flips — the crossover rate is where the two NPV profiles intersect.)

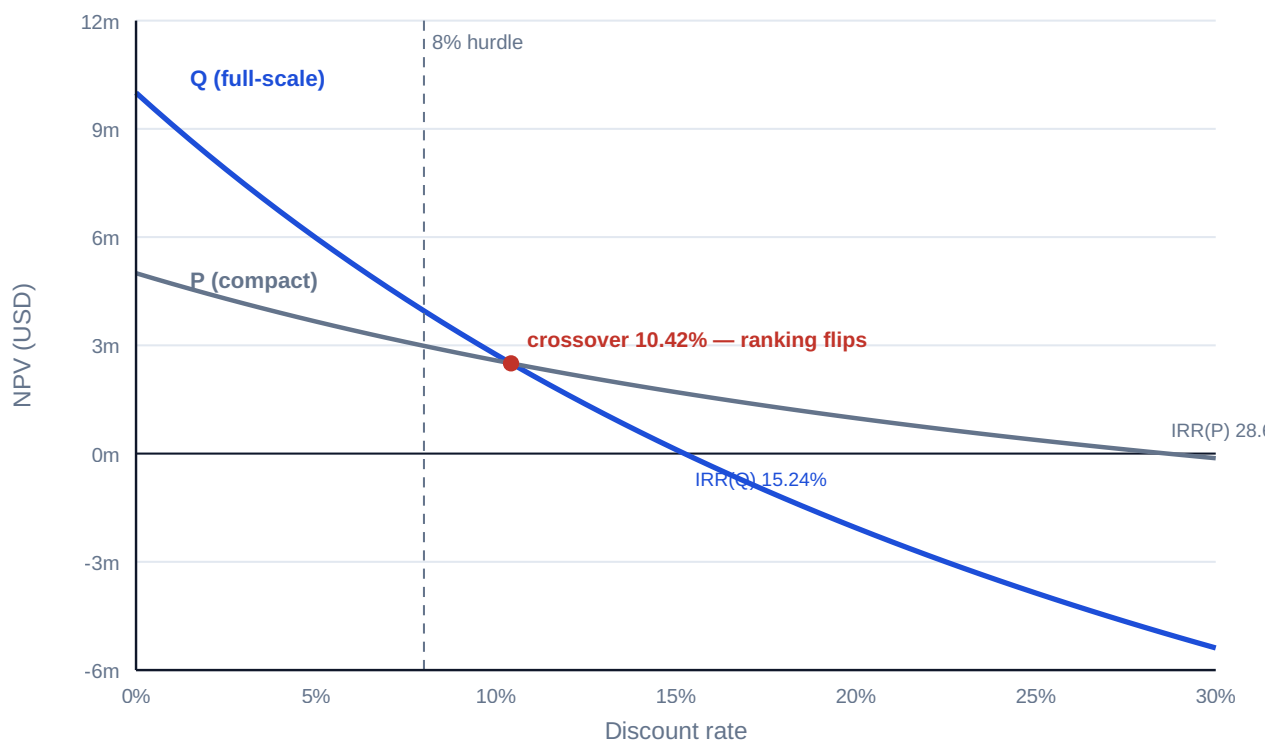


Fig 4.3.1 — Two NPV profiles and the crossover

4.3.2 Capital rationing

The problem. When the budget cannot fund every positive-NPV project, maximise **NPV per budget dollar** — rank by PI and pack the budget:

Project	I_0 (m)	NPV (m)	PI	Cumulative I_0
W	8	2.40	1.300	8
X	12	3.00	1.250	20 ← budget
Y	10	2.20	1.220	—
Z	6	1.02	1.170	—

With a USD 20m budget the PI ranking funds **W + X for NPV +5.40m**; the tempting "biggest NPV first, then fill" (X, then Y won't fit, then W) lands on the same 5.40m here, but the next-best feasible set (W + Y, +4.60m) shows what a wrong packing costs. Discipline points: PI packing is exact only when projects are divisible or the budget binds once — lumpy multi-period rationing is an optimisation problem (Domain 6's model does it honestly); and rationing itself deserves challenge, because turning away a 1.17-PI project is a financing failure as often as a screening success (Domain 9).

4.3.3 The limits of the numbers

Every measure in this domain consumes forecasts and a rate, and both are judgments wearing decimals. The professional frame: **appraisal quantifies; it does not decide strategy**. Numbers cannot see option value (the pilot that buys the right to scale), strategic foreclosure (the market position lost by not building), or the asymmetry of forecast error (Domain 8's ranges belong beside every point NPV). The board paper this domain endorses shows: NPV at the owned rate; the sensitivity of that NPV to the two or three assumptions that dominate it; IRR/MIRR as narrative; exposure via discounted payback; and the explicit statement of what the numbers cannot price. Anything less is theatre with spreadsheets.

AI in this KA

Ranking under constraints is combinatorial — machine territory — and constraint errors are silent. The governed pattern from Domain 6 applies unchanged: the optimiser proposes the portfolio; the analyst verifies the constraint set against reality (is the budget truly annual? are W and X really independent?); golden checks re-verify the NPVs being packed; and the leader owns the strategic overrides the model cannot see (4.3.3) — recorded as decisions, not adjustments smuggled into assumptions.

■ KEY TERMS — KA 4.3

Term	Meaning
Mutually exclusive	Choosing one forecloses the other; rank by NPV.
Incremental IRR	IRR of the difference project; narrates the NPV ranking.
Crossover rate	Rate where two NPV profiles intersect and rankings flip.
Capital rationing	Budget binds before value runs out; pack by PI.
Option value	Value of flexibility the static NPV cannot see.

■ SAMPLE MCQS — KA 4.3

MCQ 4.3-A [4.3.1 · Application] P: NPV +2,985,420, IRR 28.65 %. Q: NPV +3,956,260, IRR 15.24 %. Cost of capital 8 %; only one may proceed. The correct choice is: - A. P — higher IRR - B. Q — higher NPV, confirmed by an incremental IRR of 10.42 % above the hurdle - C. P — lower investment is always safer - D. both, split the budget

Rationale: Exclusive choices rank by money added: Q adds USD 970,840 more, and the extra 15m earns 10.42 % > 8 %. A is the scale-blindness pathology; C prices fear, not value; D violates the premise.

MCQ 4.3-B [4.3.2 · Application] Budget USD 20m. Projects (I₀, NPV): W (8, 2.4), X (12, 3.0), Y (10, 2.2), Z (6, 1.02). The value-maximising funded set is: - A. X and Y - B. W and X: NPV +5.40m - C. W, Y and Z - D. X and Z

Rationale: PI order W (1.300), X (1.250) packs the budget exactly for +5.40m. A needs 22m; C needs 24m; D fits (18m) but yields +4.02m — a 1.38m sacrifice for leaving W unfunded.

MCQ 4.3-C [4.3.3 · Analysis] A pilot plant shows NPV −800,000, but building it creates the option to deploy at 20× scale if the technology proves. The appraisal-sound treatment is: - A. reject — negative NPV is disqualifying - B. approve by overriding the NPV silently - C. present the static NPV alongside an explicit valuation (or structured judgment) of the scaling option, and decide on the combined case, recorded as such - D. raise the forecast cash flows until NPV turns positive

Rationale: Static NPV cannot see option value; the remedy is to price or judge the option in the open. A discards real value; B and D are the same dishonesty at different altitudes — one hides the judgment, the other disguises it as a forecast.

MCQ 4.3-D [4.3.1 · Recall] The crossover rate of two NPV profiles is: - A. the rate at which both projects' NPVs equal zero - B. the rate at which the two NPVs are equal — above it, the ranking flips - C. the average of the two IRRs - D. the cost of capital

Rationale: Crossover is the intersection of profiles (equivalently the incremental project's IRR). A describes two separate IRRs; C is arithmetic superstition; D is a property of the firm, not of the pair.

■ SELF-CHECK — KA 4.3

1. Why does incremental IRR always agree with NPV on a pairwise choice? — It tests whether the difference project clears the hurdle, which is exactly what the NPV difference measures.
2. When does PI packing fail as a rationing rule? — Lumpy projects and multi-period budget constraints; then it's an optimisation, not a sort.
3. Name three things a positive NPV cannot tell the board. — Exposure duration; sensitivity concentration; the value of flexibility and strategic position outside the modelled flows.

— Advanced topics — Domain 4

4.A.1 Reading NPV profiles like a professional

The profile (Fig 4.1.1) compresses the whole appraisal into one curve: its height at 0 % is the undiscounted surplus; its slope measures duration-sensitivity (long-dated flows steepen it); its zero-crossing is the IRR; and the distance between the hurdle and the crossing is the margin for rate error. Two profiles per decision (Fig 4.3.1) add the crossover — the complete geometry of a mutually

exclusive choice. A reviewer who asks for the profile instead of the point estimate has converted an argument about numbers into an inspection of shape.

4.A.2 Inflation-consistent appraisal

The Fisher discipline of Domain 3 (KA 3.3.1) binds hardest here: nominal flows with the nominal rate, or real flows with the real rate — and the same world for every line, including the terminal value. The classic appraisal defect is a nominal hurdle (board-set, inflation-inclusive) discounting real flows (an engineer's "today's money" forecast): NPV is systematically understated and good projects die politely. The assumption register names the world; the reviewer checks one line item end to end.

4.A.3 The reviewer's appraisal eye

The invariants: NPV at 0 % equals the raw flow sum; NPV at the IRR equals zero (substitute it back — the cheapest IRR audit that exists); MIRR lies between the reinvestment rate and the IRR; $PI > 1 \Leftrightarrow NPV > 0$ at the same rate; $EAV \times AF(r, n)$ reproduces the NPV; incremental IRR above the hurdle $\Leftrightarrow$ the bigger project's NPV is higher. Any violated line is a defect somewhere — the appraisal analogue of Domain 3's factor-table checks, and wired into this programme's golden-answer harness.

— Industry variations — Domain 4

- **Regulated utilities and availability PPPs.** Contracted revenue narrows the forecast range, so appraisal battles concentrate on the rate (and the regulator's allowed return); NPV margins are thin and Fisher errors (4.A.2) are decision-changing.
 - **Merchant power and commodities.** The forecast is the battlefield: point NPVs are close to meaningless without the scenario set (Domain 7's stress tests), and payback recovers status as a survival measure — how long must prices hold?
 - **Oil, gas and mining.** Decommissioning liabilities put the sign-change pathology (4.1.2) on almost every appraisal: MIRR and NPV are standing practice, "the IRR" is treated with suspicion by convention.
 - **Technology and corporate transformation.** Option value (4.3.3) dominates: staged investments are the norm, and static NPV is a floor, not an answer. Rationing is annual and lumpy — the optimisation caveat of 4.3.2 is the daily reality.
 - **Public-sector appraisal.** The discount rate is policy (a social time preference rate, set centrally), distributional effects sit beside NPV, and appraisal guidance is published — the numbers travel with a governance file, which is the direction this domain pushes every sector.
-

— Case study — Domain 4: the intake decision, taken properly (water / desalination)

Situation. Kestrel's board must (1) confirm the plant investment, (2) choose between intake designs P and Q, and (3) allocate the sponsor group's residual USD 20m development budget across four unrelated feeder projects (W–Z of KA 4.3.2). One meeting, three different appraisal questions.

The decisions. Build: NPV +16.18m at 8 %, IRR 12.19 %, MIRR 9.73 %, discounted payback 10.07 years — build, with the exposure noted and the two dominating assumptions (tariff escalation,

availability) sensitivity-tested per KA 4.3.3. Intake: Q over P — +970,840 more NPV, incremental IRR 10.42 % over the extra 15m; the 28.65 % on P is recorded as the intensity it is, not the ranking it isn't. Budget: W + X for +5.40m, with the un-funded 1.17-PI project Z referred to Domain 9's financing question rather than silently killed.

What the domain teaches here. Three questions, three measures, one hierarchy: NPV decided all three calls; IRR, MIRR, PI and payback each explained a facet the board needed narrated. The minute records rates, worlds (nominal), sensitivity owners and the option-value judgments — the appraisal file is the governance file.

— Case study B — Domain 4: the fund that bought percentages (infrastructure fund)

Situation. An infrastructure fund with a 9 % cost of capital repeatedly preferred short-tenor, high-IRR deals — the P-shape — over long-tenor concessions at 13–15 % IRR. Five years on, its realised portfolio return trailed its own reported deal IRRs by nearly four points.

What happened. The gap was the reinvestment fiction industrialised: each 25–30 % IRR assumed its distributions would earn the same, but the fund redeployed at market rates — when it could redeploy at all. MIRR at honest reinvestment rates (the 4.1.3 arithmetic) had flagged the true economics of every deal; it was computed, and filed. The long concessions it passed over — lower IRR, far higher NPV per dollar and decade — went to competitors who now hold them.

What the domain teaches here. A portfolio of intensities is not a portfolio of value. IRR's flattery compounds at fund level because short deals recycle the fiction; NPV and MIRR discipline is not academic tidiness — over a fund's life it is the difference between the return promised and the return delivered.

— Executive perspective — Domain 4

What a project finance director cannot delegate in this domain:

- **The hurdle.** As in Domain 3: whoever sets r sets the answer. The director owns the rate, its world (nominal or real), and the standing sensitivity band around it.
- **The measure hierarchy.** NPV decides; rates and ratios explain. The director enforces this in every paper — and personally reads the profile, not the point.
- **The exclusivity discipline.** Incremental thinking (Q–P) is the director's question in the room: "what does the extra money earn?" beats "which percentage is bigger?" every time.
- **The honesty of rejections.** Under rationing, what was not funded and why is board information; a rejected 1.17-PI project is a financing gap wearing a screening verdict.
- **The unpriced.** Option value, strategic position, forecast asymmetry — the director's overrides are legitimate exactly when they are explicit, minuted and owned (4.3.3).

— Calculation exercises — Domain 4

Exercise 4.1 $I_0 = 12,000,000$; net flows 3,000,000 · 4,000,000 · 5,000,000 · 5,000,000 in years 1–4; $r = 10\%$. Compute the NPV. Solution. $PV = 3/1.10 + 4/1.10^2 + 5/1.10^3 + 5/1.10^4$ (millions) =

$2,727,273 + 3,305,785 + 3,756,574 + 3,415,067 = 13,204,699$; **NPV = +1,204,699**. Common error: discounting year 1 at $t = 0$ (no discount) shifts every factor one period and overstates NPV by $\approx 1.19\text{m}$.

Exercise 4.2 $I_0 = 9,000,000$; level inflow 1,500,000 for 10 years. Find the IRR. Solution. $AF(r, 10) = 9/1.5 = 6.0$; solving gives **IRR = 10.56 %** ($AF(10\%) = 6.145$, $AF(11\%) = 5.889$ bracket it). Common error: reading the payback reciprocal ($1.5/9 = 16.7\%$) as the IRR — that shortcut holds only for perpetuities.

Exercise 4.3 $I_0 = 10,000,000$; inflows 2,600,000 for 6 years; reinvestment and finance rate 7 %. Compute MIRR. Solution. $FVAF(0.07, 6) = 7.153291$; $TV = 18,598,556$; $MIRR = (1.859856)^{(1/6)} - 1 = 10.90\%$. Common error: compounding the inflows for 6 periods each (rather than to a common terminal date) inflates TV and the rate.

Exercise 4.4 Machine C1: 3,000,000 capex, 4-year life, 250,000/yr opex. Machine C2: 4,200,000, 6-year life, 150,000/yr. Same duty; $r = 9\%$. Choose. Solution. C1: $PV = 3,000,000 + 250,000 \times 3.239720 = 3,809,930$; $EAC = 1,176,006$. C2: $PV = 4,200,000 + 150,000 \times 4.485919 = 4,872,888$; $EAC = 1,086,263$. **Choose C2** — cheaper by 89,743 per year. Common error: comparing PVs across unequal lives (which picks C1).

Exercise 4.5 Budget 25,000,000. Projects (I_0 ; NPV): A (10; 2.60) · B (15; 3.30) · C (8; 1.84) · D (7; 1.40). Fund the best set. Solution. PIs: A 1.260 · C 1.230 · B 1.220 · D 1.200. **Greedy PI packing fails here:** A + C + D fits (25) for +5.84m, but **A + B (25 exactly) yields +5.90m**. With lumpy projects the rule is: use PI to shortlist, then enumerate feasible sets (or optimise). This is the 4.3.2 caveat as arithmetic.

— Practitioner's toolkit — Domain 4

Adoption-ready artefacts; adapt headings to your organisation, then keep them stable.

Toolkit 4.T.1 — The appraisal one-pager (per decision)

Decision question (accept/reject · exclusive choice · rationing) · cash-flow source and world (nominal/real, per 3.T.1) · rate and its owner · **NPV at the owned rate** · profile sketch or IRR/MIRR · discounted payback · PI (if rationing) · EAV (if unequal lives) · two-way sensitivity on the dominating assumptions · unpriced factors, stated · recommendation and the named accountable approver.

Toolkit 4.T.2 — IRR pathology checklist

- [] Sign changes counted; more than one → MIRR + NPV only, "the IRR" banned from the paper.
- [] Scale stated beside every percentage (I_0 and NPV in money).
- [] Tenors aligned before any cross-project rate comparison (else EAV).
- [] Reinvestment assumption named; MIRR computed when $IRR > \text{hurdle} + 5$ points.
- [] IRR substituted back: $NPV(IRR)$ recomputes to zero.
- [] Incremental IRR computed for every exclusive pair; agrees with NPV ranking.

Toolkit 4.T.3 — Rationing worksheet

Columns: project · I_0 · NPV · PI · strategic notes/dependencies. Steps: rank by PI → shortlist to $\sim 2 \times$ budget → enumerate feasible sets (lumpy) → record funded set, rejected set with reasons, and the financing referral for high-PI rejects (Domain 9).

— Exam preparation — Domain 4

The calculation traps. Forgetting to deduct I_0 (MCQ 4.1-A distractor D) · discounting from $t = 0$ (Exercise 4.1) · payback reciprocal as IRR (Exercise 4.2) · ranking exclusives by IRR (4.3.1) · greedy PI with lumpy budgets (Exercise 4.5) · comparing PVs across unequal lives (Exercise 4.4) · quoting one IRR for sign-changing flows (4.1.2) · MIRR terminal value mis-compounded (Exercise 4.3) · nominal/real mixing imported from Domain 3.

Reflection questions. 1. Your board paper shows one number: "IRR 22 %". List the five questions this domain obliges you to ask before anyone votes. (Scale? Sign changes? Tenor? Reinvestment? NPV at our rate?) 2. When is a negative-NPV decision defensible — and what must the record contain? (4.3.3: explicit option/strategic value, owned and minuted.) 3. Which invariant of 4.A.3 would have caught the last appraisal error you saw? (Most often: $NPV(IRR) \neq 0$ on substitution, or $EAV \times AF \neq NPV$.)

— Domain 4 summary

Appraisal turns Domain 3's machinery into decisions, under one hierarchy: **NPV decides; everything else explains.** NPV earns primacy by additivity, scale-awareness and the honest reinvestment assumption; IRR narrates a margin of safety but carries three standing pathologies — multiple roots, scale-blindness, the reinvestment fiction — of which MIRR repairs only the last; payback and its discounted form measure exposure, never value; PI ranks value per scarce dollar under rationing (with the lumpy-budget caveat proven in Exercise 4.5); EAV makes unequal lives commensurable. Mutually exclusive choices resolve by NPV, narrated by incremental IRR and the crossover geometry; rationing resolves by disciplined packing plus the financing question for what was turned away; and the limits of the numbers — options, strategy, forecast asymmetry — are stated in the open, as owned judgments. The Kestrel thread continues into Domain 5 (is the project bankable, not merely valuable?) and Domain 6 (the model that industrialises every calculation this domain taught).

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